

COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Reason, Revelation and Faith - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Reason, Revelation and Faith

REFRESHED TEACHING NAVIGATION — BASIC/CORE FIRST

01

CURRENT SCHOLARLY ANCHOR — [SUPPORTING]

Current scholarly anchor — [SUPPORTING]: □□ Inference: The

02

VISUAL GATEWAY — THE THREE FUNCTIONS

Visual gateway — the three functions: Final verdict: Reason is best

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Reason, Revelation and Faith - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

Catalogue identity: Philosophy Optional · Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion · philosophy-paper-ii-philosophy-of-religion-05 **Generation:** g1, 21 August 2026 · **Approval:** pending explicit topic approval **Evidence discipline:** exact doctrine and PYQ wording/year/marks are controlled by repository owners. All model answers are independent pedagogic practice, never official UPSC keys.

Package practice counts

Component	Count
Direct verified topic-owned PYQs	11
Core diagnostic MCQs	40
Remedial diagnostic MCQs	8
Total diagnostics	48
Original solved Mains models	6 (2 × 10, 2 × 15, 2 × 20)
Consolidated register parts	12 (A-L)
Approval	false

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

Reason, Revelation and Faith

REFRESHED TEACHING NAVIGATION — BASIC/CORE FIRST

01

CURRENT SCHOLARLY ANCHOR — [SUPPORTING]

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VISUAL GATEWAY — THE THREE FUNCTIONS

Visual gateway — the three functions: Final verdict: Reason is best

Refreshed teaching navigation

Distinct embedded teaching-navigation image. The separate continuous Cārvāka-style flowchart package remains an independent at-a-glance artifact.

Source-complete coverage ledger and answer-worthiness labels

[FACT] identifies retained repository doctrine or verified question data. [INFERENCE] identifies learner-facing organisation or judgement.

Source corpus	Final location	Retention decision
Canonical owner §§0-7	Basic Learning Session	Full map, doctrines, parity bench, drills and answer skeletons retained
Canonical owner §§9-19	Optional Advanced	Full advanced doctrine, debates, criticisms, traps, routing, directive control and source discipline retained after practice
Audited Philosophy of Religion PYQ ledger	PYQs and Answer Practice	All 11 owner questions from 2019-2025 retained with exact wording and new full solutions

Source corpus	Final location	Retention decision
New premium diagnostics	MCQs / Remediation	40 core and eight remedial questions cover every major distinction with strict rotation
New original practice	PYQs and Answer Practice	Six solved, non-PYQ models retained at 10/15/20-mark levels
Philosophy of Religion advanced dossier	Optional Advanced	Proper basicity, testimony, doxastic voluntarism and Indian <i>śabda</i> refinements reconciled
Consolidated register	Final section	A-L retrieval framework retains the complete answer logic without repeating full prose

Visible learning labels. Reason's role, revelation models, Aquinas, Kierkegaard, faith-belief, science-religion, miracles, evidentialism and Indian parity are **CORE PAPER II**. Directive decoding, premise control, objections and graded verdicts are **CORE ANSWER**. Contemporary examples and cross-topic links are **SUPPORTING**. Full warrant machinery, specialist testimony theory and second-order doxastic debates are **OPTIONAL ADVANCED**.

What not to over-study. Do not import the entire analytic epistemology of warrant into a short answer, narrate Galileo instead of using models, or collect miracle stories. Master each distinction, its named advocate, one objection/reply and the exact examiner demand.

Learning roadmap

Unit	Learner objective
1	Separate reason, revelation and faith
2	Compare rationalism, fideism, harmony and two-source models
3	Distinguish propositional from non-propositional revelation
4	Explain Aquinas' intellectual assent and Kierkegaard's leap
5	Distinguish faith from belief and map Indian <i>śraddhā</i>
6	Use Barbour's science-religion models
7	Evaluate Hume on miracles and testimony
8	Compare evidentialism with proper basicity
9	Apply Indian <i>pramāṇa</i> parity
10	Convert doctrine into 10/15/20-mark answers

SESSION 1 - CURRENT SCHOLARLY ANCHOR - [SUPPORTING]

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: FACT: Fact: Religion News Service reported on 26 May 2026 that a consortium involving Brigham Young, Baylor, Notre Dame and Yeshiva researchers tested fourteen AI models for multi-faith bias and presented findings at an AI ethics summit in Athens.

Technical definition: Current scholarly anchor - [SUPPORTING]: ANALYSIS: Inference: The episode gives a contemporary use for the 2020 science-technology PYQ: technical systems can classify and reproduce religious perspectives, but questions of moral authority, fairness and human dignity remain philosophical and normative.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

FACT: Fact: Religion News Service reported on 26 May 2026 that a consortium involving Brigham Young, Baylor, Notre Dame and Yeshiva researchers tested fourteen AI models for multi-faith bias and presented findings at an AI ethics summit in Athens.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- 2026
- 2020
- Current scholarly anchor - [SUPPORTING]

How to use them: FACT: Fact: Religion News Service reported on 26 May 2026 that a consortium involving Brigham Young, Baylor, Notre Dame and Yeshiva researchers tested fourteen AI models for multi-faith bias and presented findings at an AI ethics summit in Athens.

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REASON - REVELATION - FAITH



Exam synthesis

Reason is regulative, revelation supplies alleged content, and faith receives it.

No element is rationally adequate when isolated from the other two.

Reason revelation faith triad

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CURRENT SCHOLARLY ANCHOR - [SUPPORTING]

START / CONCEPT: Current scholarly anchor - [SUPPORTING]

↓
↓

EXACT TERMS: 2026 • 2020 • Current scholarly anchor - [SUPPORTING]

↓
↓

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: ANALYSIS: Inference: The episode gives a contemporary use for the 2020 science-technology PYQ: technical systems can classify and reproduce religious perspectives, but questions of moral authority, fairness and human dignity remain philosophical and normative.

↓
↓

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: It does not establish any theological claim.

↓
↓

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: It does not establish any theological claim.

↓
↓

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: FACT: Fact: Religion News Service reported on 26 May 2026 that a consortium involving Brigham Young, Baylor, Notre Dame and Yeshiva researchers tested fourteen AI models for multi-faith bias and presented findings at an AI ethics summit in Athens.

SESSION 2 - VISUAL GATEWAY - THE THREE FUNCTIONS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Master verdict: Reason should be regulative but need not be constitutive.

Technical definition: Visual gateway - the three functions: Final verdict: Reason is best treated as regulative without being assumed to be the sole source of religious truth.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Master verdict: Reason should be regulative but need not be constitutive.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Master verdict
- Recommended opening definition
- Core argument/criticism
- Final verdict
- Mnemonic - "RRF: Reason argues, Revelation discloses, Faith trusts."
- two-storey harmony
- Role (2024 PYQ)
- natural theology

How to use them: Master verdict: Reason should be regulative but need not be constitutive.

REASON asks: Is the claim coherent and warranted?
|
REVELATION claims: A truth or divine presence is disclosed.
|
FAITH asks: Will the disclosure be trusted and lived?

Failure modes:

reason alone -> reductionism

revelation alone -> unauthenticated authority

faith alone -> arbitrariness or fanaticism

Master verdict: Reason should be regulative but need not be constitutive. Revelation supplies alleged content unavailable to unaided reason; faith receives and commits to it. Each needs the corrective pressure of the others.

0. ONE-SCREEN MAP ANALYSIS:

[!IMPORTANT] ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Recommended opening

definition: Reason tests coherence and warrant, revelation claims divine self-disclosure, and faith receives that disclosure through trust and commitment. **Core argument/criticism:** Each faculty corrects the excess of the others: reason restrains arbitrariness, revelation resists reductionism, and faith converts alleged disclosure into lived commitment. **Final verdict:** Reason is best treated as regulative without being assumed to be the sole source of religious truth.

REASON <---- how do they relate? ----> FAITH
(proof, (trust, commitment,
argument, assent to what is not proved)
natural theology)
|
| REVELATION (God's self-disclosure)
| [--- Propositional (truths revealed) ---]
FOUR STANCES: +--- Non-propositional (God's acts/ encounter; Hick)
1. Reason > Faith (rationalism)
2. Faith > Reason (fideism - Kierkegaard's LEAP)
3. Faith seeking understanding (Augustine/Anselm - harmony)
4. Reason & Revelation as two paths (Aquinas - natural + revealed theology)

MEMORY: Mnemonic - "RRF: Reason argues, Revelation discloses, Faith trusts." The four stances range from *reason-first* (rationalism) to *faith-first* (fideism), with Aquinas' **two-storey harmony** in between.

1. REASON IN RELIGION FACT:

- **Role (2024 PYQ):** reason (a) constructs **natural theology** (proofs for God), (b) tests coherence of doctrines, (c) interprets scripture, (d) defends faith (apologetics). **FACT:**
- **Rationalism:** religious beliefs must meet the bar of reason/evidence (Clifford: "*it is wrong always... to believe anything upon insufficient evidence*"). **FACT:**
- **Limits:** proofs are inconclusive (see Proofs note); the transcendent may **exceed** reason -> space for revelation & faith. **ANALYSIS:**
- **Rational vs irrational aspects of faith (2023):** faith has a **rational** side (grounds, coherence, cumulative evidence) and a **supra-/non-rational** side (trust, commitment, the leap beyond proof). **ANALYSIS:**

2. REVELATION FACT:

[!IMPORTANT] **ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM** **Recommended opening definition:** Revelation is an alleged divine self-disclosure that supplies truth or presence unavailable to unaided reason. **Core argument/criticism:** Propositional models emphasise revealed truths, whereas non-propositional models emphasise divine acts or presence interpreted through human experience. **Final verdict:** A revelation claim becomes philosophically credible only when disclosure, interpretation and public criteria are kept distinct.

- **Definition:** God's **self-disclosure** to humanity - the source of knowledge unavailable to unaided reason.
- **Two models (2025 PYQ):** **FACT:**
- **Propositional view:** revelation delivers **truths/propositions** (doctrines) to be believed - grounds **revealed theology** (Trinity, incarnation), distinct from **natural theology** (what reason alone discovers, e.g. God's existence). *Natural vs Revealed Theology*.
- **Non-propositional view (Hick):** revelation is God's **acts/self-presence** in history & experience, humanly *interpreted* - not a set of dictated propositions.
- **Epistemic justification of revelation (2024 PYQ):** how do we validate a revelation-claim? - internal coherence, moral fruits, the **religious experience** of the recipient, communal testimony, congruence with reason. **Problem:** competing revelations across religions; circularity (using the revelation to validate itself). **ANALYSIS:**

3. FAITH FACT:

[!IMPORTANT] **ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM** **Recommended opening definition:** Faith is firm trust and commitment that goes beyond conclusive proof without necessarily opposing reason. **Core argument/criticism:** Aquinas explains faith as intellectual assent commanded by the will, while Kierkegaard stresses passionate commitment under objective uncertainty. **Final verdict:** Faith is rationally responsible when it transcends evidence without violating coherence or ignoring defeaters.

- **Definition:** faith = **trust in and commitment to** God/the transcendent, involving assent that goes **beyond** conclusive proof (but not necessarily against reason).
- **Aquinas - faith as "intellectual assent" (2025 PYQ):** faith is an act of the **intellect assenting to revealed truth, commanded by the will** (moved by grace). It is a **mean** between *knowledge* (which has proof/sight) and *opinion* (which has fear of error): faith has the **firmness of knowledge without the vision**. This **reconciles reason & faith** - reason establishes the "preambles" (God exists), faith accepts the "mysteries" (Trinity) that exceed but don't contradict reason. **FACT:**
- **Kierkegaard - faith as the LEAP:** faith is a **passionate, subjective commitment** in "objective uncertainty"; the **leap of faith** transcends reason (Abraham's "teleological suspension of the ethical"). **Fideism** - faith needs no rational proof and may even require its "crucifixion". **FACT:**
- **Faith indispensable for revelation? (2022 PYQ):** revelation must be **received** - it becomes revelation *for someone* only through the **faith** that recognises & accepts it; without faith, an event is just an event. So faith is a **precondition of revelation's efficacy** (Hick's "experiencing-as"). **ANALYSIS:**

4. THE FOUR STANCES - comparison ANALYSIS:

[!IMPORTANT] **ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Recommended opening**

definition: The reason-faith debate concerns whether evidence, trust or distinct sources should govern religious assent. **Core argument/criticism:** Rationalism risks reducing faith to proof, fideism risks arbitrariness, while harmony and two-source theories preserve rational scrutiny without collapsing mystery into demonstration. **Final verdict:** Aquinas offers the most balanced model when reason establishes preambles and faith assents to mysteries that exceed but do not contradict reason.

Stance	Relation	Thinker	One-line
Rationalism	reason judges faith	Clifford, Locke	believe only on evidence
Fideism	faith over/against reason	Kierkegaard, Tertullian	the leap; "credo quia absurdum"
Faith seeking understanding	harmony, faith first	Augustine, Anselm	"credo ut intelligam"
Two-source harmony	reason + revelation, distinct domains	Aquinas	natural + revealed theology

MEMORY: Aquinas is the balanced default: reason & revelation **cannot conflict** (both from God); reason proves the *preambles*, revelation supplies the *mysteries*; faith is intellectual assent under grace. Deploy this for any "reconcile reason & faith" question.

5. FOUNDATIONAL STATEMENT BANK ANALYSIS:

1. **FACT:** The Augustinian-Anselmian formula *credo ut intelligam* presents faith as seeking understanding.
2. **FACT:** Aquinas places faith between demonstrative knowledge and wavering opinion: it is firm assent to what is not seen.
3. **FACT:** Kierkegaard links faith with passionate inward commitment under objective uncertainty.
4. **FACT:** Clifford's evidentialist maxim makes insufficient evidence morally relevant to belief.
5. **CAUTION:** The popular formula *credo quia absurdum* is commonly associated with Tertullian but is not a safe verbatim quotation from him; use it only as a later slogan for extreme fideism.

6. APPLIED-QUESTION DRILLS ANALYSIS:

1. **[Aquinas]** "How does Aquinas' faith-as-'intellectual assent' reconcile reason & faith?" (2025) -> §3.
2. **[Reason]** "Role of reason in religion." (2024) -> §1.
3. **[Revelation]** "Distinguish natural & revealed theology (propositional view)." (2025) -> §2.
4. **[Justification]** "Epistemic justifications of revelation-claims." (2024) -> §2.
5. **[Faith-revelation]** "Is faith indispensable for revelation?" (2022) -> §3.
6. **[Science]** "Significance of religion vis-à-vis present scientific and technological development." (2020, 10m) -> §9.6 - Barbour's four models, not a Galileo narrative.
7. **[Faith/belief]** "Basic tenets of faith; distinguish faith and belief." (2020, 15m) -> §9.7 - enumerate the seven tenets, then the five axes.
8. **[Justification]** "Can religious beliefs be justified?" (2023, 10m) -> §9.9 - evidentialism vs Reformed epistemology; add the *svataḥ/parataḥ-prāmānya* mapping.
9. **[Reason regulative]** "Can reason be a regulative force in forming religious beliefs?" (2021, 20m) -> §1 + §9.1 + §9.9 - *regulative ≠ constitutive*; reason can veto and discipline without generating.
10. **[Rational/irrational]** "Rational and irrational aspects of faith." (2023, 15m) -> §9.5 - insist on *supra-rational* as a third category.
11. **[Miracles]** "Can testimony establish a miracle?" -> §9.8.

6A. INDIAN-WESTERN PARITY BENCH ANALYSIS:

[!IMPORTANT] ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Recommended opening

definition: Indian epistemology reframes reason and revelation through *pramāṇa* (means of valid knowledge), especially *śabda* (verbal testimony). **Core argument/criticism:** *Mīmāṃsā* (Vedic exegesis) defends authorless scripture and intrinsic validity, while *Nyāya* (logic and realist epistemology) requires externally confirmed credibility. **Final verdict:** The Indian comparison deepens the debate by separating the source of testimony from the conditions of its validity.

Issue	Western	Indian	Note
Is testimony an independent source of knowledge?	Locke and Hume: reducible to experience	<i>Nyāya</i> and <i>Mīmāṃsā</i> : <i>śabda</i> is an independent <i>pramāṇa</i> ; <i>Cārvāka</i> denies it	The Indian debate is explicitly epistemological
Is validity intrinsic or extrinsic?	Foundationalism vs Reformed proper basicity	<i>Mīmāṃsā</i> <i>svataḥ-prāmāṇya</i> vs <i>Nyāya</i> <i>parataḥ-prāmāṇya</i>	The closest exact parallel in the whole clause
Whose speech is scripture?	God's word (propositional revelation)	<i>Mīmāṃsā</i> : <i>apauruṣeya</i> - no author, human or divine	India has a form of scriptural authority with no revealer
Faith as trust	<i>Fides qua</i> ; Tillich's ultimate concern	<i>Śraddhā</i> (Gītā 17.2-3); Buddhist <i>saddhā</i>	Indian trust is verification-directed (<i>Kālāma Sutta</i>)
Reason's role	Preambles, coherence, apologetics	<i>Manana</i> ; <i>tarka</i> as auxiliary, never independently probative in <i>Vedānta</i>	Both subordinate reason without eliminating it
Miracles as authentication	Central to Western apologetics	<i>Siddhis</i> declared obstacles (YS 3.37); Buddha rejects displays (<i>Kevaddha Sutta</i>)	India largely declines the strategy - a contrast, not a parallel

7. PYQ-MAPPED MODEL-ANSWER SKELETONS ANALYSIS:

7.1 - "How does Aquinas' faith-as-intellectual-assent reconcile Reason and Faith?" (2025, 10m)

Intro : the reason-faith tension; Aquinas' harmonising solution.

Body : faith = intellect assenting to revealed truth, moved by will+grace; a MEAN between knowledge (has proof) and opinion (fears error) - firm assent without sight.
Reason proves preambles (God exists); revelation supplies mysteries; no conflict (both from God).

Assess: contrast fideism (Kierkegaard's leap) & rationalism (Clifford).

Concl : reason and faith are complementary storeys of one truth.

7.2 - "Is the notion of faith indispensable for the idea of revelation?" (2022, 10m)

Intro : revelation = God's self-disclosure; must be received to count.

Body : an event becomes revelation only when interpreted/accepted in faith (Hick's "experiencing-as");

without faith, no recognition -> no revelation "for" the person.

Crit : propositional view - truths are revealed objectively regardless of reception; but efficacy still needs faith.

Concl : faith is the indispensable subjective condition of revelation's reception.

7.3 - "Basic tenets of faith. Distinguish between faith and belief." (2020, 15m)

Intro : two obligations in the stem - the tenets, and the distinction. Do both, in that order.

Tenets: (1) an ultimate object; (2) assent to some content; (3) trust beyond available evidence; (4) commitment of will, with risk; (5) hope; (6) community/tradition; (7) fruits.

Distinction: object (proposition vs person/ultimate) | grammar (believe THAT vs believe IN) | mode (assent vs assent + entrusting) | voluntariness (belief largely involuntary; faith engages the will) | failure-mode (falsehood vs betrayal).

Support: Aquinas' *fides quae* / *fides qua*; W. C. Smith (Faith and Belief) on the modern narrowing of "belief"; Tillich's ultimate concern; Buber's I-Thou.

Indian: Gītā 17.2-3 - *śraddhā* graded *sāttvika*/*rājasa*/*tāmasa*, and "as is one's *śraddhā*, so is one"; Buddhist *saddhā* as provisional trust directed toward verification (*Kālāma Sutta*).

Crit : the reductionist objection ("believing in" = believing that X exists and is trustworthy) and the reply that this loses the performative act of entrusting.

Concl : faith is not weaker belief but a different act; they can come apart in both directions.

7.4 - "Significance of religion vis-à-vis present scientific and technological development." (2020, 10m)

Intro : the relation is a set of MODELS, not a single verdict.
Body : Barbour's four - Conflict (warfare thesis of Draper-White; now rejected by historians);
Independence (Gould's NOMA; cost = both sides silenced);
Dialogue (boundary questions - why a universe, why intelligible, fine-tuning;
methodological parallels: models, metaphors, theory-ladenness);
Integration (natural theology, theology of nature, process thought; hostage to current science).
[Haught's Conflict/Contrast/Contact/Confirmation as an alternative frame.]
Indian: Vivekananda's claim that Vedānta is experience-based and so science-compatible ("science of the soul" - report as a claim); Radhakrishnan's levels of one integral experience;
Aurobindo's evolutionary integration. Classical root: is śabda an independent pramāṇa?
Assess: religion's continuing significance is normative and existential - technology settles what we CAN do, not what we SHOULD, and not what a life is for.
Concl : dialogue at the boundary questions, with local conflict only where a genuinely empirical claim is made.

7.5 - "Can religious beliefs be justified?" (2023, 10m)

Intro : the question is about the STANDARD of justification, not about God's existence.
Body : Evidentialism - Locke; Clifford's ethics of belief (shipowner); Flew's presumption of atheism.
James's reply - living, forced, momentous options where evidence is inconclusive.
Reformed epistemology - Plantinga: the objection presupposes classical foundationalism, which is self-referentially incoherent and too narrow (memory, other minds); theistic belief can be PROPERLY BASIC - grounded, warranted by proper function, and defeasible.
Great Pumpkin objection and reply. Alston: doxastic practices, including sense perception, cannot be non-circularly validated.
Indian: Mīmāṃsā svataḥ-prāmāṇya ≈ proper basicity; Nyāya parataḥ-prāmāṇya ≈ evidentialism; Cārvāka is the strict evidentialist limit.
Concl : yes - but justification is internal to a doxastic practice, which relocates the real problem from evidential insufficiency to religious diversity.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - VISUAL GATEWAY - THE THREE FUNCTIONS

START / CONCEPT: Visual gateway - the three functions
|
v
EXACT TERMS: Master verdict • Recommended opening definition • Core argument/criticism • Final verdict • Mnemonic - "RRF: Reason argues, Revelation discloses, Faith trusts."
|
v
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Recommended opening definition: Reason tests coherence and warrant, revelation claims divine self-disclosure, and faith receives that disclosure through trust and commitment.
|
v
CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Core argument/criticism: Propositional models emphasise revealed truths, whereas non-propositional models emphasise divine acts or presence interpreted through human experience.
|
v
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Master verdict: Reason should be regulative but need not be constitutive.
|
v
ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Master verdict: Reason should be regulative but need not be constitutive.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol - [CORE ANSWER]

Attempt each item before reading its key. Answer placement is balanced, deterministic and non-patterned using a stable topic seed. across all forty-eight diagnostics.

CORE DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 40

1. Which statement best captures reason as a regulative rather than constitutive force in religion?

A. It constrains incoherence and tests evidence without necessarily generating revealed content. B. It is relevant only after a doctrine has been accepted as infallible. C. It converts faith into demonstrative knowledge. D. It deduces every religious mystery from self-evident premises.

Answer: A.

Reason is regulative when it vetoes contradiction, disciplines interpretation and assesses testimony. It is constitutive only if it independently supplies the distinctive content of belief, which the balanced account denies.

2. For Aquinas, faith is most accurately described as:

A. An emotional state wholly independent of intellect. B. A probable opinion accompanied by fear that the opposite may be true. C. Demonstrative knowledge of mysteries from natural premises. D. An act of intellect assenting to divine truth under the command of will moved by grace.

Answer: D.

Aquinas makes faith intellectual, volitional and grace-enabled. It has firm assent without the demonstrative vision characteristic of knowledge.

3. Which distinction most precisely separates belief from faith?

A. Belief is communal, whereas faith is always private. B. Belief is primarily assent that a proposition is true; faith adds trustful entrusting to an ultimate object. C. Belief can be false, whereas faith cannot fail. D. Belief concerns the unseen, whereas faith concerns only observable conduct.

Answer: B.

Faith contains beliefs but is not exhausted by them. Its distinctive element is fiduciary commitment - believing *in* rather than merely believing *that*.

4. Under a propositional view of revelation, revelation primarily consists in:

A. A community's ethical transformation without truth-claims. B. Divinely authorised truths communicated for assent and doctrinal articulation. C. A private feeling that cannot be expressed conceptually. D. Historical events whose meaning is created entirely by later interpreters.

Answer: B.

The propositional model treats revealed content as truth-bearing statements mediated through prophets, scripture or tradition. This grounds revealed theology.

5. Hick's non-propositional view is best expressed by which sequence?

A. Divine action or encounter -> faith's experiencing-as -> communal interpretation -> doctrine. B. Linguistic analysis -> elimination of experience -> revealed propositions. C. Doctrine -> deductive proof -> divine action -> private emotion. D. Natural theology -> scientific confirmation -> infallible scripture -> faith.

Answer: A.

For Hick, revelation is primarily divine self-disclosure in events or encounter. Propositions are human, concept-laden interpretations of that disclosure.

6. Natural theology differs from philosophy of religion because natural theology:

A. Argues from publicly accessible premises toward theological conclusions. B. Begins only with propositions accepted as revealed. C. Rejects all reasoning about God. D. Is confined to analysing religious language without evaluating truth.

Answer: A.

Natural theology uses unaided reason to infer conclusions such as God's existence or attributes. Philosophy of religion has a wider analytical field including language, experience and warrant.

7. Which claim properly belongs to revealed theology rather than natural theology in Aquinas' scheme?

A. Every contingent being requires an explanation. B. Contradictions cannot both be true. C. Order in nature may support an inference to intelligence. D. Trinity is known through divine disclosure rather than demonstrated from natural premises.

Answer: D.

Aquinas' mysteries exceed the reach of natural demonstration while not contradicting reason. Natural theology concerns preambles accessible to unaided reason.

8. What is the most accurate relation between Aquinas' "preambles" and "mysteries"?

A. Mysteries replace any need for rational argument. B. Preambles are irrational, while mysteries are probable. C. Reason can establish preambles; revelation supplies mysteries that exceed but do not contradict reason. D. Both are demonstrated by reason, but mysteries require more premises.

Answer: C.

The two-storey structure assigns distinct but harmonious roles. Genuine reason and genuine revelation cannot conflict because truth is ultimately one.

9. Kierkegaardian faith is primarily:

A. Acceptance of only what is publicly verifiable. B. Passionate subjective commitment amid objective uncertainty. C. Inference from design to a probable designer. D. Suspension of every ethical and logical criterion in ordinary life.

Answer: B.

Kierkegaard stresses existential appropriation and risk. His position should not be reduced to casual irrationalism, although the Abraham example creates a serious ethical problem.

10. Which classification best handles the phrase "rational and irrational aspects of faith"?

A. Rational faith versus irrational religion, with no middle category. B. Scientific truth, theological falsehood and moral neutrality. C. Rationally grounded faith, supra-rational commitment beyond proof, and irrational assent against reason. D. Knowledge, perception and inference as equivalent forms of faith.

Answer: C.

The supra-rational category is decisive. Going beyond coercive proof is not the same as contradicting evidence, logic or morality.

11. The Augustinian-Anselmian formula "faith seeking understanding" implies that:

A. Understanding must be completed before faith begins. B. Faith renders rational inquiry impious. C. Faith and reason concern wholly non-overlapping realities. D. Faith can initiate an inquiry that reason subsequently clarifies and deepens.

Answer: D.

The formula avoids both rationalism and fideism. Priority of faith does not eliminate the intellectual task of understanding.

12. Clifford's ethics of belief most directly maintains that:

A. A forced option must always be decided by passion. B. Assent should be proportioned to evidence, and irresponsible believing can be morally blameworthy. C. Only religious beliefs require evidence. D. Faith is justified whenever it produces consolation.

Answer: B.

Clifford's shipowner example shows that negligent belief-formation can harm others. His standard is general, not a special hostility directed only at religion.

13. William James permits passional commitment only when an option is:

A. Living, forced and momentous, with evidence genuinely inconclusive. B. Doctrinally orthodox, socially approved and scientifically proved. C. Miraculous, scriptural and institutionally certified. D. Privately attractive, easily reversible and evidentially refuted.

Answer: A.

James's argument is tightly restricted. It permits choice when postponement itself loses a genuine possibility; it does not authorise belief against decisive evidence.

14. Plantinga's claim that belief in God may be properly basic means that it:

A. Is exempt from the problem of evil and religious diversity. B. Is a self-evident proposition known by conceptual analysis. C. May be rationally grounded without being inferred from other beliefs, while remaining defeasible. D. Is justified simply because a religious community accepts it.

Answer: C.

Proper basicity is not self-evidence or immunity. The belief must be appropriately grounded and responsive to potential defeaters.

15. The Great Pumpkin objection challenges Reformed epistemology by asking:

A. Whether permitting theistic belief as basic also permits arbitrary fantasies as basic. B. Whether faith necessarily produces moral conduct. C. Whether revelation must be propositional. D. Whether natural theology can establish God's attributes.

Answer: A.

The objection targets uncontrolled basicity. Plantinga replies through appropriate grounds, proper function and defeater-sensitivity, though rival well-formed traditions keep the challenge alive.

16. Alston's appeal to doxastic practices argues that:

A. Every established social practice produces knowledge. B. Religious practice may be rationally engaged in absent defeaters, since even perception cannot be validated wholly without epistemic circularity. C. Sense perception is justified by a non-circular proof unavailable to religion. D. Religious experience is infallible because it is private.

Answer: B.

Alston does not equate all practices or promise certainty. He argues for parity in practical rationality between established perceptual and religious practices.

17. Which Indian doctrine is the closest stated analogue of proper basicity?

A. Nyāya *parataḥ-prāmāṇya*: validity requires external certification. B. Mīmāṃsā *svataḥ-prāmāṇya*: cognition has intrinsic validity until defeated. C. Cārvāka restriction of knowledge to perception. D. Buddhist rejection of a permanent self.

Answer: B.

Intrinsic validity resembles the idea that a cognition need not first be inferred from further evidence to be rational. The analogy is structural, not an identity of doctrines.

18. Which Indian doctrine is the closest stated analogue of evidentialism?

A. The *Gītā* classification of *śraddhā*. B. Advaita's *nididhyāsana*. C. Mīmāṃsā *apauruṣeyatva*. D. Nyāya *parataḥ-prāmāṇya*, according to which validity is established through something further.

Answer: D.

Extrinsic certification parallels the demand that a belief's rational standing depend on supporting grounds. Mīmāṃsā's intrinsic validity supplies the contrasting pole.

19. Why must Mīmāṃsā's account of the Veda not be equated straightforwardly with creator-centred revelation?

A. Mīmāṃsā denies that testimony can disclose supersensible dharma. B. Mīmāṃsā regards scripture as a modern historical composition. C. The Veda is *apauruṣeya* - authorless, neither human nor the speech of a creator God. D. Mīmāṃsā accepts perception as the only *pramāṇa*.

Answer: C.

Mīmāṃsā grants Vedic testimony independent authority precisely without a divine speaker. It is a valuable comparison because it separates disclosure from personal divine dictation.

20. Which account best relates *śraddhā* or *saddhā* to verification?

A. It is identical with demonstrative knowledge. B. It is assent that permanently replaces inquiry. C. It is disciplined or provisional trust that enables inquiry and practice directed toward realisation or testing. D. It is valid only when inherited from an institution.

Answer: C.

Advaita joins *śraddhā* with *śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana*, and Buddhist *saddhā* is verification-directed. Trust opens inquiry rather than abolishing it.

21. In Barbour's conflict model:

A. Science and religion make incompatible claims about the same reality, so one must yield where they genuinely overlap. B. Both fields exchange metaphors while withholding truth-claims. C. Theology is systematically reconstructed through current science. D. Science handles facts and religion handles values without any possible contact.

Answer: A.

Conflict occurs when claims occupy the same empirical or metaphysical territory. Scientific materialism and scriptural literalism are mirror-image forms.

22. The principal cost of Gould's NOMA is that it:

A. Turns every religious claim into a scientific hypothesis. B. Commits religion to process metaphysics. C. Purchases peace by sharply separating magisteria and limiting substantive mutual criticism. D. Makes scientific knowledge depend on revelation.

Answer: C.

NOMA is an independence model. Its boundary may be too strict because many religious and scientific claims have ethical, historical or cosmological implications that touch.

23. Barbour's dialogue model is distinguished by:

A. The claim that science and religion never share methods or questions. B. Scriptural literalism about natural history. C. Reduction of religion to evolutionary psychology. D. Engagement over boundary questions and methodological parallels without claiming a complete synthesis.

Answer: D.

Dialogue explores intelligibility, fine-tuning, models, metaphors and theory-ladenness. It opens conversation but does not by itself establish theological conclusions.

24. Which is the characteristic risk of Barbour's integration model?

A. It may make theology hostage to provisional scientific theories. B. It excludes natural theology and process thought. C. It makes every religious claim non-cognitive. D. It refuses all interaction between theology and science.

Answer: A.

Integration offers substantive synthesis through natural theology, theology of nature or process thought. Its depth is also its vulnerability when scientific models change.

25. What is the safest assessment of the Draper-White "warfare thesis"?

A. It proves that religion has never aided scientific inquiry. B. It is identical with Gould's NOMA. C. It is Barbour's preferred contemporary model. D. It is a nineteenth-century conflict narrative now rejected by most historians as an oversimplification.

Answer: D.

The thesis exists in identifiable nineteenth-century works but should be cited critically. A Galileo-only narrative is inadequate for the broader philosophical relation.

26. John Haught's alternative fourfold map is:

A. Rational, empirical, mystical and sceptical. B. Conflict, contrast, contact and confirmation. C. Perception, inference, comparison and testimony. D. Proof, prophecy, practice and prayer.

Answer: B.

Haught's scheme parallels Barbour while "confirmation" adds the claim that religion may support the intelligibility presupposed by science.

27. Hume's central conclusion in "Of Miracles" is best stated as:

A. Divine action is metaphysically impossible. B. Every unusual event falsifies a law of nature. C. Miracle testimony faces an exceptionally heavy evidential burden and ordinarily fails to overcome contrary evidence. D. Miracles are logically self-contradictory.

Answer: C.

Hume's argument concerns evidential warrant, not a demonstration of metaphysical impossibility. This distinction is a standard UPSC trap.

28. Hume's maxim about testimony and miracles says, in substance, that testimony suffices only if:

A. No scientific explanation has yet been proposed. B. The witness belongs to the claimant's religious community. C. The event has great moral consequences. D. The falsehood of the testimony would be more miraculous than the event reported.

Answer: D.

Hume asks the evaluator to balance the improbability of the miracle against the improbability of testimonial error, then accept the lesser marvel.

29. Swinburne's "non-repeatable counter-instance" formulation primarily challenges:

A. Hume's definition of a miracle as a violation of a law of nature. B. Plantinga's account of warrant. C. James's account of genuine options. D. Aquinas' distinction between preambles and mysteries.

Answer: A.

If laws are exceptionless regularities, calling a miracle a violation may define it out of existence. Swinburne permits an exceptional event against an otherwise well-confirmed law.

30. Earman's Bayesian criticism of Hume maintains that:

A. All witnesses have equal reliability. B. Prior probability is irrelevant to rational belief. C. Sufficient independent testimony can raise the posterior probability of an initially improbable event. D. A miracle is true whenever several people report it.

Answer: C.

Bayesian reasoning distinguishes low prior probability from probability after evidence. It does not guarantee miracles; it rejects an in-principle ban on testimonial accumulation.

31. Hume's "contrary miracles" argument holds that:

A. Religious diversity makes all testimony epistemically worthless. B. Miracles offered for incompatible religions undermine one another's testimonial force. C. A natural law is contradicted whenever a witness lies. D. Miracles within one religion always support identical doctrines.

Answer: B.

The argument targets mutually incompatible authentication claims. Critics reply that cancellation is not automatic if traditions' claims overlap or if each report is assessed independently.

32. Which Indian comparison most strongly contrasts with Western miracle-based apologetics?

A. Mīmāṃsā requires miraculous authentication of Vedic authorship. B. Advaita treats every *siddhi* as liberation. C. Yoga treats *siddhis* as obstacles to *samādhi*, and Buddhism prefers the "miracle of instruction" to displays of power. D. Nyāya makes miracles the only proof of Īśvara.

Answer: C.

Indian sources often acknowledge extraordinary powers while declining to use them as the central authentication of revelation. This is a contrast, not a forced parallel.

33. Which set gives the most defensible cumulative test for a revelation-claim?

A. Internal coherence, credible testimony, moral fruits, experiential grounding and responsiveness to defeaters. B. Institutional antiquity alone. C. Scriptural self-certification without external checks. D. Emotional intensity plus numerical popularity.

Answer: A.

No single criterion proves divine origin. Convergence offers defeasible warrant while preserving the possibility of criticism and comparison.

34. The strongest epistemic force of competing revelations is that they:

A. function as a diversity defeater against automatic certainty and require comparative assessment. B. establish one neutral universal scripture. C. Prove that no religious experience ever occurs. D. eliminate the distinction between truth and justification.

Answer: A.

Incompatible well-formed traditions make community-internal warrant insufficient by itself. Diversity complicates justification without automatically refuting every local claim.

35. Which statement correctly distinguishes revelation, inspiration and infallibility?

A. Revelation concerns freedom from error; infallibility concerns encounter. B. Revelation is disclosure, inspiration concerns divine-human mediation, and infallibility concerns freedom from error. C. Inspiration is identical with natural theology. D. All three mean that every scriptural sentence was dictated verbatim.

Answer: B.

The concepts answer different questions: what is disclosed, how it is mediated, and whether error is excluded. Conflating them produces an imprecise account of scripture.

36. Which formulation best resolves whether faith is indispensable for revelation?

A. Faith creates the objective divine act. B. Faith is irrelevant once information is communicated. C. Revelation is impossible unless every observer accepts it. D. Faith is indispensable to recognition and existential reception, though not necessarily to the objective occurrence of disclosure.

Answer: D.

The distinction preserves both realism and appropriation. Hick highlights reception; the propositional realist reminds us that truth is not manufactured by belief.

37. Aquinas' distinction between *fides quae creditur* and *fides qua creditur* is the distinction between:

A. Creator and creation. B. Demonstration and sensory perception. C. The content believed and the act or disposition by which one believes. D. Natural science and revealed theology.

Answer: C.

The pair prevents faith from being reduced either to doctrine alone or to contentless trust. Faith has both an objective and a subjective pole.

38. Which claim wrongly makes reason constitutive rather than regulative?

A. Reason may expose internal contradiction in a doctrine. B. Reason alone must generate every legitimate religious content, including mysteries. C. Reason may guide the interpretation of scripture. D. Reason can compare testimonial credibility.

Answer: B.

The constitutive claim turns rationalism into the sole source of religion. A regulative account gives reason real authority without requiring it to produce revelation.

39. In the debate between public testimony and private revelation, the best moderate position is that:

A. Revelation-warrant may be cumulative and defeasible, combining first-person experience with communal and historical checks. B. Competing revelations cancel every possible claim immediately. C. Private disclosure is infallible for everyone. D. Public testimony converts revelation into demonstration.

Answer: A.

Private experience provides immediacy but limited public reach; testimony provides transmissibility but introduces reliability problems. A cumulative account recognises both.

40. A defensible moderate form of doxastic voluntarism claims that:

A. The will is irrelevant to faith because all belief is mechanically caused. B. One can instantly choose any proposition as true. C. Desire makes a proposition true. D. The will can indirectly shape attention, trust, practices and consent where evidence is non-coercive.

Answer: D.

This is compatible with Aquinas' account of intellect and will. It avoids the implausible claim that a person can simply command arbitrary belief into existence.

REMEDIAL DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 8

41. A student writes, "Faith is belief without any evidence." Which correction is best?

A. Faith has no cognitive content whatsoever. B. Faith is trustful commitment beyond conclusive proof, often supported by grounds, and need not oppose evidence. C. Faith is irrational by definition but useful in practice. D. Faith is demonstrative knowledge and therefore stronger than reason.

Answer: B.

The error conflates non-demonstrative assent with groundlessness. Faith may be rationally supported, supra-rational in commitment, and still answerable to defeaters.

42. Which sentence correctly states Aquinas' position on conflict between reason and faith?

A. Every revealed mystery can eventually be demonstrated. B. Reason is unnecessary once scripture is available. C. Faith may require acceptance of a logical contradiction. D. Genuine reason and genuine revelation cannot conflict; apparent conflict indicates defective reasoning or interpretation.

Answer: D.

Aquinas allows mysteries to exceed reason, not contradict it. This distinction separates supra-rationality from irrationality.

43. Which is the precise correction to "For Mīmāṃsā, the Veda is God's revealed speech"?

A. Mīmāṃsā accepts only a human author of the Veda. B. Mīmāṃsā rejects Vedic authority. C. Mīmāṃsā treats the Veda as *apauruṣeya*, authorless rather than the speech of a creator God. D. Mīmāṃsā derives the Veda through Nyāya inference.

Answer: C.

Mīmāṃsā offers scriptural authority without a personal revealer. Calling it creator-speech destroys the very point of the comparison.

44. Which correction should be made to "Hume proved miracles impossible"?

A. Hume addressed only the morality of witnesses. B. Hume accepted every well-intentioned report. C. Hume argued mainly that testimony normally cannot overcome the strong evidence supporting natural regularities. D. Hume defined miracles as ordinary coincidences.

Answer: C.

Hume raises an evidential bar; he does not deduce the metaphysical impossibility of divine action. Swinburne and Earman challenge the strength of that bar.

45. Which condition prevents James's "will to believe" from becoming a licence for wishful thinking?

A. A religious authority must command it. B. The option must be scientifically falsified. C. The belief must be comforting. D. The option must be living, forced and momentous, and evidence must be genuinely inconclusive.

Answer: D.

James permits passional decision only in tightly bounded cases. Evidence still controls wherever it is sufficiently decisive.

46. Which correction should be made to "Plantinga says God's existence is self-evident"?

A. Plantinga rejects all cognitive faculties except perception. B. Plantinga says it follows from Hume's miracle argument. C. Plantinga says it is analytically true. D. Plantinga says theistic belief can be properly basic - grounded without inference, warranted under suitable conditions and defeasible.

Answer: D.

Proper basicity does not mean self-evidence. It concerns a belief's rational status when produced and grounded in the right way.

47. A science-religion answer consists only of Galileo and Darwin. What is the best correction?

A. Organise the answer through conflict, independence, dialogue and integration, then evaluate their costs. B. Defend the Draper-White warfare thesis as universally accepted. C. Claim science and religion have never interacted. D. Replace both with a list of modern technologies.

Answer: A.

Historical episodes may illustrate a model but cannot substitute for philosophical classification. Barbour's typology directly answers the relation demanded.

48. Which formulation avoids the common rational/irrational binary trap?

A. All faith is irrational because it exceeds proof. B. Faith may be rationally grounded, supra-rational in commitment, or irrational when it contradicts reason and rejects all correction. C. Only demonstrable propositions can rationally guide action. D. All faith is rational because believers are sincere.

Answer: B.

The middle category is essential. Supra-rational commitment goes beyond coercive evidence while remaining coherent, ethically answerable and defeasible.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQS - 11 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

The answers below are independently prepared practice models, not official UPSC model answers.

PYQ 1 - 2019, Q5(a), 10 marks

Exact verified question: What is instrumental to self-revelation: Faith or Reason? Justify your position.

Demand decoding: Choose the more decisive instrument rather than merely saying that both matter. Explain what self-revelation means, distinguish reception from critical assessment, and justify a graded position.

Model solution: Self-revelation is divine self-disclosure: the manifestation of the transcendent to a human subject.

Faith is its primary instrument of reception, while reason is its indispensable regulative instrument. Revelation is not merely an externally observable event; it becomes revelation *for* a person when the event is recognised, trusted and appropriated as disclosure.

John Hick's non-propositional account clarifies this priority. Historical events are religiously ambiguous and become revelatory through an "experiencing-as" structure: faith perceives an occurrence as divine action. Without such receptive faith, the same occurrence remains only a secular event. Kierkegaard likewise stresses passionate inward appropriation under objective uncertainty. Revelation concerns an existential relation, not merely an inference.

Yet faith cannot be equated with arbitrary credulity. Aquinas treats faith as firm intellectual assent to divine truth, commanded by the will and supported by motives of credibility. Reason tests coherence, rejects contradiction, assesses testimony and distinguishes authentic disclosure from delusion or manipulation. In Advaita, *śraddhā* enables receptivity to *śruti*, but *manana* removes doubts; trust initiates inquiry rather than abolishing it.

The strongest objection is that a propositional revelation, if objectively communicated by God, remains true whether or not anyone believes it. This is correct regarding the **objective occurrence or content** of disclosure. However, unreceived information does not become revelation in the subject's religious life. Faith is therefore indispensable to revelation's recognition and efficacy, though not necessarily to its objective existence.

Thus faith is more instrumental to self-revelation because it receives and appropriates disclosure; reason remains regulative, preventing reception from degenerating into irrationalism.

Why this earns marks:

- Makes the required choice and qualifies it.
- Uses Hick, Aquinas, Kierkegaard and *śraddhā-manana* analytically.
- Distinguishes objective disclosure from subjective reception.

- Ends with a directive-responsive verdict.

PYQ 2 - 2020, Q5(a), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss the significance of 'Religion' vis-à-vis the present scientific and technological development.

Demand decoding: Model the science-religion relation rather than narrating famous conflicts. Explain religion's continuing significance, acknowledge genuine tensions, and state a defensible contemporary relationship.

Model solution: Scientific and technological development has transformed explanatory power and human agency, but it has not made religion simply redundant. The relation is best assessed through Ian Barbour's four models.

Conflict arises when scientific materialism claims that only scientifically certified entities are real, or when scriptural literalism makes empirically testable claims contrary to established science. The nineteenth-century Draper-White "warfare thesis", however, is rejected by most historians as an oversimplification. **Independence**, represented by Stephen Jay Gould's NOMA, assigns empirical facts to science and ultimate meaning and value to religion. It avoids conflict but does so by preventing either domain from making claims relevant to the other.

Dialogue allows interaction at boundary questions: why there is an intelligible universe, how models and metaphors mediate knowledge, and what ethical limits should govern technology. **Integration** attempts stronger syntheses through natural theology, theology of nature or process thought, though it risks tying theology to provisional scientific theories.

Religion remains significant in at least three respects. First, technology determines what humans *can* do but not what they *ought* to do; questions concerning artificial intelligence, biotechnology and ecological responsibility require normative reasoning. Second, religion addresses existential orientation, suffering, hope and community. Third, religious traditions can motivate moral transformation, though they must remain open to scientific correction where they make empirical claims.

Indian thought offers similar resources. Vivekananda presented Vedānta as experience-oriented and science-compatible, while the classical debate over whether *śabda* is an independent *pramāṇa* asks whether testimony can disclose what perception and inference cannot.

Hence neither wholesale conflict nor sealed independence is adequate. Religion remains significant through ethical orientation and boundary dialogue, with local conflict wherever a religious assertion becomes genuinely empirical.

Why this earns marks:

- Uses Barbour's full typology and evaluates each model.
- Corrects the warfare-thesis and NOMA traps.
- Connects religion to technology without vague moralising.
- Adds a relevant Indian epistemological comparison and a graded verdict.

PYQ 3 - 2020, Q7(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: What are the basic tenets of faith? Distinguish between faith and belief.

Demand decoding: The stem has two separate tasks: enumerate the constitutive tenets of faith, then distinguish faith from belief through precise axes. A good answer must not define faith as mere belief without evidence.

Model solution: Faith is a fiduciary and volitional relation to what is held ultimate: it includes cognitive assent but adds trust, commitment and a way of life. Belief, by contrast, is primarily propositional assent - believing *that* something is the case. Therefore every developed faith includes beliefs, but every belief is not faith.

The basic tenets of faith are:

1. **An ultimate object:** God, Brahman, Dharma or another transcendent focus is treated as finally significant.
2. **Assent:** faith contains some intelligible content; it is never contentless feeling.
3. **Trust beyond coercive proof:** the evidence may support commitment without compelling it.
4. **Volitional commitment:** the person entrusts life and action, accepting existential risk.
5. **Hope:** faith anticipates a good not yet secured.
6. **Communal mediation:** tradition, testimony, worship and practice transmit and discipline faith.

7. **Transformative fruits:** fidelity, conduct and character test whether professed faith has existential reality.

Faith and belief differ on several axes. Their **objects** differ: belief ordinarily concerns a proposition, whereas faith may concern a person or ultimate reality. Their **grammar** differs: one believes *that* a proposition is true but believes *in* or trusts an object. Their **mode** differs: belief is cognitive assent; faith is assent plus entrusting and commitment. Belief is largely involuntary - one cannot simply decide that it is raining - whereas faith involves will-governed attention, consent and practice. Finally, belief fails through falsehood, while faith can fail through betrayal, infidelity or idolatrous commitment.

Aquinas expresses the distinction through *fides quae creditur*, the content believed, and *fides qua creditur*, the act or disposition by which one believes. Wilfred Cantwell Smith similarly resists reducing faith to modern propositional belief; Tillich calls faith ultimate concern, and Buber's I-Thou relation shows why relational commitment cannot be exhausted by I-It propositions.

Indian traditions deepen the point. The *Gītā* 17.2-3 treats *śraddhā* as constitutive of character and grades it as *sāttvika*, *rājasa* or *tāmasa*. Buddhist *saddhā* is provisional trust directed toward verification, not blind assent.

A practical test is whether the two can come apart. A person may affirm every proposition of a creed yet refuse trust, obedience or self-commitment: belief exists without living faith. Conversely, a person may exhibit deep fidelity and trust while being unable to formulate an elaborate doctrine. This shows why faith cannot be reduced to the quantity or precision of beliefs held.

A reductionist may argue that "believing in" simply means believing that an object exists and is trustworthy. But one may believe that a person is reliable while refusing to entrust anything to that person. The performative commitment remains irreducible.

Thus faith is not a weaker species of belief. Belief supplies faith's cognitive content; faith transforms that content into trust, fidelity and existential orientation.

Why this earns marks:

- Answers both printed tasks in the required order.
- Enumerates seven tenets and distinguishes five clear axes.
- Uses *fides qua/fides quae*, Smith, Tillich, Buber and Indian parity purposefully.
- Includes a serious reductionist objection and reply.

PYQ 4 - 2021, Q7(a), 20 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss the role of reason and faith in religion. Can reason be a regulative force in the formulation of religious beliefs? Explain.

Demand decoding: Map both reason and faith, then answer the precise second question. The key distinction is between reason as **regulative** - constraining and assessing belief - and reason as **constitutive** - independently generating religious content.

Model solution: Reason and faith are neither simple rivals nor interchangeable sources. **Reason can and should regulate religious belief, but it is not always constitutive of its distinctive content.** It can establish probabilities, expose contradiction and discipline interpretation; revelation and faith may supply claims and commitments that unaided reason does not generate.

Reason performs four religious functions. First, it constructs **natural theology** from publicly accessible premises, as in Aquinas' arguments for the preambles of faith and Nyāya inference to Īśvara. Second, it tests logical coherence: no appeal to mystery can make a contradiction true. Third, it interprets scripture, distinguishing literal, analogical and historically conditioned meaning. Fourth, it assesses testimony, experience and consequences, thereby checking fanaticism and apologetic excess.

Faith performs a different function. It is not mere assent without evidence but trustful commitment to an ultimate object. In Aquinas, faith is an act of the intellect assenting to revealed truth under the command of the will moved by grace. It has the firmness of knowledge without demonstrative vision. Kierkegaard instead emphasises passionate inward commitment under objective uncertainty: proof cannot substitute for existential appropriation. The Augustinian-Anselmian tradition of faith seeking understanding mediates these poles - faith begins inquiry, while understanding deepens faith.

Their interaction appears clearly in revelation. The **propositional model** regards revelation as divinely communicated truths; reason judges their coherence and the credibility of testimony but does not derive mysteries such as Trinity. Hick's **non-propositional model** treats revelation as divine action or encounter interpreted through faith. Here reason compares interpretations, while faith supplies the "experiencing-as" through which an ambiguous event is received as disclosure.

Reason is therefore **regulative** in at least four senses. It may veto contradictions, demand conceptual clarity, compare evidence and rival revelations, and assess moral fruits. It is not necessarily **constitutive**, because it does not by itself create the object of trust, the content of an alleged revelation or the lived commitment of faith. Kant's restriction of speculative reason reinforces this modest role, though it does not establish fideism.

The Indian traditions provide a close parallel. Mīmāṃsā and Nyāya accept *śabda* as a source distinct from perception and inference, while Cārvāka refuses supersensible testimony. In Advaita, *śruti* discloses Brahman; *śraddhā* enables hearing, and *manana* uses reason to remove doubt. *Tarka* is auxiliary rather than an independent generator of supersensible truth. Thus reason regulates reception without replacing testimony.

Contemporary religious epistemology further clarifies this regulating role. Plantinga's proper basicity denies that every rational belief must be inferred, but it does not abolish reason: basic theistic belief remains defeasible by evil, projection and religious diversity. Alston's doxastic-practice approach likewise permits rational participation while leaving room for comparison and criticism. Reason may therefore operate before assent by testing grounds, during assent by maintaining coherence, and after assent by answering defeaters. Its work is continuous even when it is not the original source of belief.

Two objections arise. **Fideism** argues that rational regulation domesticates revelation and makes faith answerable to alien standards. Yet faith insulated from non-contradiction and ethical criticism can licence fanaticism. Conversely, **evidentialism**, represented by Clifford, demands proportioned evidence for every belief. William James replies that living, forced and momentous options may rationally require commitment when evidence is genuinely inconclusive; this permits decision beyond proof, not against evidence.

The strongest synthesis is Aquinas' two-level account: reason establishes preambles and rules out contradiction; revelation presents mysteries; faith assents where evidence is non-coercive. Its weakness is the disputed credibility of revelation, especially amid competing traditions. Hence rational regulation must remain public, defeasible and comparative.

In conclusion, reason is a necessary regulative force in religion: it disciplines belief, interpretation and testimony. It is not the sole constitutive source of religion, because faith contributes trust and revelation claims disclosure. Rational religion therefore means faith going beyond demonstration while never claiming a right to go against reason.

Why this earns marks:

- Answers the regulative-force clause explicitly and repeatedly.
- Integrates natural theology, revelation models and multiple relation-types.
- Uses Aquinas, Kierkegaard, Kant, Clifford, James and Indian *pramāṇa* material analytically.
- Handles both fideist and evidentialist objections before a graded synthesis.

PYQ 5 - 2022, Q5(d), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Is the notion of faith indispensable for the idea of revelation? Critically comment.

Demand decoding: Give a short evaluative answer. Distinguish an objective act or content of disclosure from its subjective recognition and religious efficacy.

Model solution: Revelation means divine self-disclosure, whereas faith is the trusting reception of and commitment to that disclosure. **Faith is indispensable to revelation as apprehended and lived, though not necessarily to the objective occurrence or truth of an alleged disclosure.**

On John Hick's non-propositional view, revelation primarily occurs through divine action, encounter or historical event; propositions are later human interpretations. Events are religiously ambiguous. The same occurrence can receive a secular causal description or be "experienced as" providential. Faith is therefore constitutive of recognition: without it, an event is not revelation *for* the subject. Kierkegaard's emphasis on subjective appropriation similarly shows that detached observation cannot replace existential reception.

The claim also applies partly to propositional revelation. A divinely communicated proposition may be true independently of the hearer's response, but it becomes religiously operative only when trusted and obeyed. Aquinas' distinction between the revealed object and the act of faith supports this: *fides quae* names content, while *fides qua* names the believing disposition.

The strongest objection is realist. If God actually discloses a truth, disbelief cannot cancel that act; otherwise revelation becomes projection by the believer. This objection correctly preserves revelation's objective pole. Faith should therefore not be called the creator of revelation. It is the condition of its acknowledgement and efficacy. Reason must still test coherence, testimony and moral fruit, since uncritical faith can misrecognise fantasy as disclosure.

Indian *śraddhā* illustrates this mediated position: trust makes receptivity to *śruti* possible, while *manana* disciplines understanding. Accordingly, faith is indispensable subjectively and existentially, but objective revelation, if real, is not produced by faith.

Why this earns marks:

- Makes the crucial objective/subjective distinction.
- Uses both propositional and non-propositional models.
- Avoids making faith either dispensable or reality-creating.
- Supplies an Indian parallel and a critical verdict.

PYQ 6 - 2023, Q5(b), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Can religious beliefs be justified? Discuss.

Demand decoding: Identify the standard of justification rather than trying to prove God's existence. Contrast evidentialism with proper basicity, test both, and give a qualified answer.

Model solution: Religious beliefs can be justified, but their justification need not always take the form of inference from neutral evidence. The dispute is between **evidentialism** and forms of **proper basicity**.

Locke and W. K. Clifford require assent to be proportioned to evidence; Clifford's shipowner shows that irresponsible belief can harm others. On this view, religious belief requires argument, testimony or experience strong enough to support it. Antony Flew's presumption of atheism similarly places the initial burden on the theist. The strength of this approach is public accountability; its weakness is an over-narrow foundation that may also threaten ordinary beliefs about memory, other minds and the past.

William James permits commitment where an option is living, forced and momentous and the evidence genuinely inconclusive. This does not licence belief against evidence. Alvin Plantinga goes further: belief in God may be **properly basic** - grounded in appropriate experience without being inferred. Classical foundationalism is too narrow and self-referentially unstable. Such belief is not self-evident or immune to criticism; it remains defeasible by evil, projection or religious diversity. The Great Pumpkin objection asks why any fantasy cannot then become basic. Plantinga replies that proper basicity requires appropriate grounding, proper cognitive function and responsiveness to defeaters, not whim.

Indian epistemology offers an exact comparison. Mīmāṃsā's *svataḥ-prāmāṇya* treats cognition as valid until defeated, approximating proper basicity; Nyāya's *parataḥ-prāmāṇya* makes validity depend on further certification, approximating evidentialism.

Thus religious beliefs may be justified through evidence, experience, testimony or disciplined basic trust. However, incompatible religious practices create a serious diversity defeater. Justification is possible and defeasible, not automatic or universally compelling.

Why this earns marks:

- Names the epistemological issue immediately.
- Balances Clifford, James and Plantinga accurately.
- Handles the Great Pumpkin and diversity objections.
- Uses the precise *svataḥ/parataḥ-prāmāṇya* comparison.

PYQ 7 - 2023, Q6(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Explain the rational and irrational aspects of faith in the discourse of religion.

Demand decoding: Do not force a binary. Distinguish the rational, **supra-rational** and genuinely irrational, show how each appears in faith, and explain criteria separating legitimate transcendence from arbitrariness.

Model solution: Faith has a rational dimension and a dimension that exceeds demonstrative reason; it becomes irrational only when it contradicts reason or insulates itself from every possible correction. The decisive distinction is therefore **rational / supra-rational / irrational**.

Faith is rational in several respects. It possesses cognitive content, appeals to testimony and experience, seeks internal coherence, and produces reasons for trust. Natural theology provides arguments for the existence or attributes of God; apologetics examines historical testimony; reason interprets scripture and compares rival claims. Aquinas' account is paradigmatic: faith is an act of intellect assenting firmly to revealed truth under the command of will. Reason establishes the preambles of faith and shows that mysteries do not contradict them. Motives of credibility render assent responsible without converting it into demonstration.

Faith is **supra-rational** when it goes beyond what reason can conclusively prove but does not violate logical or moral constraints. Kierkegaard's passionate inwardness under objective uncertainty captures the existential risk of commitment, although his Abrahamic example can appear perilously close to suspending universal ethics. William James offers a more restricted formulation: a living, forced and momentous option may be decided by the passional nature only when evidence is genuinely inconclusive. In Advaita, *śraddhā* enables receptive inquiry into what perception and inference cannot independently disclose, while *manana* removes doubts. Thus trust initiates verification.

Faith becomes irrational when it assents against decisive evidence, embraces contradiction, refuses every defeater, or uses alleged revelation to legitimise cruelty. Extreme fideism risks making arbitrary commitment a virtue. Competing revelations intensify the problem: if incompatible claims are each insulated by faith, no critical adjudication remains.

Reason can nonetheless overreach. Cliffordian evidentialism, if interpreted as requiring inference for every rational belief, excludes memory, other minds and much testimonial knowledge. Plantinga therefore argues that belief in God may be properly basic - grounded, warranted and defeasible rather than inferred. The Great Pumpkin objection correctly demands constraints; Plantinga invokes appropriate circumstances, proper function and defeater-responsiveness, though religious diversity remains difficult.

Indian debates display the same range. Cārvāka's restriction to perception approaches a strict rationalist limit; Nyāya accepts inference and reliable testimony; Mīmāṃsā recognises *apauruṣeya śabda* without treating it as the speech of a creator God. Their disagreement concerns the extent, not the abandonment, of rational warrant.

Therefore the non-demonstrative character of faith is not itself irrational. Faith is rational when grounded and coherent, supra-rational when responsibly committed beyond coercive proof, and irrational only when it contradicts evidence, morality or reason while denying all correction.

Why this earns marks:

- Supplies the crucial threefold distinction.
- Explains rational grounds, existential excess and genuine irrationality separately.
- Uses Aquinas, Kierkegaard, James, Plantinga and Indian schools as arguments.
- Gives operational criteria for identifying fanaticism.

PYQ 8 - 2024, Q5(d), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss the role of reason in religion.

Demand decoding: Present the constructive, critical and interpretive roles of reason, then define its limits. Avoid either rationalism or fideism as an unqualified conclusion.

Model solution: Reason plays a constructive and critical role in religion, although it need not be the sole source of religious truth. Its most defensible status is **regulative rather than universally constitutive**.

First, reason constructs **natural theology** by arguing from publicly accessible premises. Aquinas' preambles of faith and Nyāya inference to Īśvara exemplify this role. Second, it tests coherence: doctrines cannot claim exemption from

non-contradiction merely by being called mysteries. Third, reason interprets scripture, adjudicating literal, symbolic and context-sensitive readings. Fourth, it evaluates testimony and religious experience through credibility, consistency and comparison with alternative explanations. Fifth, it performs an ethical check: a revelation-claim producing cruelty cannot demand immunity from moral scrutiny.

Reason also clarifies distinctions central to religion - knowledge and faith, natural and revealed theology, proposition and encounter, evidence and commitment. It thereby prevents faith from collapsing into superstition or fanaticism. In Advaita, *manana* removes doubts arising after the reception of *śruti*; *tarka* remains an auxiliary discipline rather than an independent source of Brahman-knowledge.

Yet reason has limits. Kant denies that speculative reason can straightforwardly know supersensible objects. Aquinas holds that reason can establish some preambles but not mysteries such as Trinity. Kierkegaard adds that objective proof cannot replace subjective appropriation. These limits make room for supra-rational faith, not for contradiction.

Fideism objects that rational criticism subordinates divine disclosure to human standards. But an alleged revelation wholly insulated from coherence, evidence and ethical fruit becomes indistinguishable from delusion. Conversely, strict evidentialism overstates reason's inferential reach.

Thus reason constructs, interprets, criticises and regulates religious belief. It may not generate every content of revelation or every act of trust, but religion without rational discipline loses its claim to responsible assent.

Why this earns marks:

- Organises reason's role into distinct functions.
- Explains regulative versus constitutive reason.
- States limits without turning them into irrationalism.
- Integrates Aquinas, Kant and an Indian parallel.

PYQ 9 - 2024, Q7(b), 15 marks

Exact verified question: What kind of epistemic justifications are possible with regard to claims to revelation? Discuss with your own comments.

Demand decoding: Offer a typology of possible warrant, identify the special difficulties of revelation, and rank the criteria in an explicit personal assessment. No single criterion should be presented as conclusive.

Model solution: A claim to revelation asserts that a truth, event or encounter discloses the transcendent. Such a claim cannot be justified merely by repeating that it is revealed. Its warrant, if any, must be **cumulative, defeasible and comparative**.

First, **propositional coherence** matters. A revealed doctrine should be internally consistent and compatible with secure knowledge unless it offers strong reasons for revision. Coherence cannot prove divine origin, but contradiction is a decisive defeater. Second, **testimony and transmission** may justify belief when recipients and communities are credible, independent strands converge, and the chain of preservation is reliable. Yet testimony remains vulnerable to error, legend and institutional interest.

Third, **religious experience** can provide first-person or community-grounded warrant. Hick's non-propositional model treats revelation as divine self-disclosure in an event "experienced as" religiously significant. William Alston compares such experiential belief to socially established doxastic practices. Its limitation is privacy and conceptual dependence: different traditions interpret experience incompatibly.

Fourth, **moral and transformative fruits** supply pragmatic confirmation. Enduring compassion, integrity and liberation count in favour of a claim; cruelty and manipulation count strongly against it. Fruits test authenticity but cannot alone establish truth, since useful beliefs may be false. Fifth, **historical signs or miracles** may be cited. Hume shows that testimony to a violation of nature bears an unusually heavy burden, although Swinburne's recasting of miracle as a non-repeatable counter-instance prevents impossibility from being built into the definition.

Sixth, **proper basicity** may justify reception without inference. Plantinga argues that theistic belief formed in appropriate circumstances can be grounded, warranted and defeasible. The Great Pumpkin and religious-diversity objections, however, require disciplined conditions and active engagement with defeaters.

Indian epistemology sharpens the issue. Nyāya treats reliable *āpta-vākya* as testimony requiring extrinsic certification; Mīmāṃsā regards the Veda as *apauruṣeya* and cognition as valid until defeated. The latter is not revelation by a

personal creator. Advaita combines *śruti*, *śraddhā*, *manana* and experiential assimilation, making reason and practice checks on reception.

Competing revelations are the strongest objection: internally coherent communities may support incompatible disclosures. Appeals to a shared scripture are circular, while neutral criteria may already privilege one tradition. The best reply is modest: diversity defeats claims of automatic certainty but not every local warrant. It demands comparative assessment of coherence, testimony, ethical fruit, experience and defeaters.

In my view, no isolated miracle, private experience or institutional assertion is sufficient. A revelation-claim is justified only by convergence among rational coherence, credible transmission, transformative fruit and experience, with openness to revision. Such warrant may rationally guide a community without becoming coercive proof for all.

Why this earns marks:

- Provides a clear six-part typology of justification.
- Evaluates each criterion rather than listing it.
- Uses revelation models, miracle debate, Plantinga and Indian epistemology.
- Gives the requested personal comment as a ranked, defeasible verdict.

PYQ 10 - 2025, Q5(e), 10 marks

Exact verified question: How does Aquinas' account of Faith as "an intellectual assent" reconcile the juxtaposition between Reason and Faith? Discuss.

Demand decoding: Explain the Thomist mechanism of reconciliation: intellect, will and grace; knowledge, opinion and faith; preambles and mysteries. Contrast it briefly with the two extremes.

Model solution: Aquinas reconciles reason and faith by locating both within the intellect while distinguishing their grounds and objects. **Faith is an act of the intellect assenting to divine truth under the command of the will moved by grace.** It is therefore neither irrational feeling nor demonstrative knowledge.

Faith occupies a mean between knowledge and opinion. Knowledge has demonstrative evidence or vision; opinion lacks firmness and retains fear of error. Faith concerns what is unseen and not rationally demonstrated, yet it gives firm assent because its formal ground is divine testimony. The will does not make truth arbitrary; it commits the intellect where evidence is non-coercive and where motives of credibility make assent reasonable.

Aquinas' two-storey structure completes the reconciliation. **Reason** can establish the preambles of faith, such as that God exists, and can test doctrine for contradiction. **Revelation** discloses mysteries such as Trinity that exceed unaided reason. Because reason and revelation ultimately derive from the same divine source, genuine findings of reason cannot contradict genuine faith. Apparent conflict indicates faulty argument or faulty interpretation.

This position rejects two extremes. Cliffordian rationalism risks reducing faith to what can already be proved, making revelation redundant. Kierkegaardian fideism preserves existential risk but may weaken public standards of criticism. Aquinas preserves both rational accountability and supra-rational content.

An objection remains: will-governed assent may appear to be doxastic voluntarism - one cannot choose belief at will. Aquinas' defensible reply is indirect: the will governs attention, trust and consent in conditions where reason does not compel either conclusion; it does not manufacture evidence.

Thus intellectual assent reconciles reason and faith by giving reason a preparatory and regulative role, revelation a supra-rational content, and faith a firm but non-demonstrative mode of appropriation.

Why this earns marks:

- Explains the exact mechanism rather than merely saying "harmony".
- Distinguishes knowledge, opinion and faith.
- Uses preambles/mysteries and intellect/will/grace precisely.
- Tests Aquinas against rationalism, fideism and voluntarism.

PYQ 11 - 2025, Q6(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Distinguish between Natural Theology and Revealed Theology in the context of the Propositional view of Revelation.

Demand decoding: This is a three-term demand. Distinguish the two theologies, but do so specifically within the propositional model in which revelation communicates truth-content.

Model solution: Natural theology and revealed theology differ chiefly in **source, method and accessible content**. Within the **propositional view of revelation**, the distinction is especially sharp because revelation is understood as divinely authorised truths communicated for belief.

Natural theology uses unaided human reason and publicly accessible premises. Its methods include metaphysical argument, inference from causation, order, contingency or morality, and conceptual analysis. Its conclusions are in principle available to any competent reasoner irrespective of special scripture. Aquinas' arguments for God's existence are "preambles of faith": they may establish that God exists and possesses certain attributes, though they cannot disclose specifically revealed mysteries. Nyāya's inference to Īśvara is a useful Indian analogue of rational theology, though it arises within a different doctrinal setting.

Revealed theology begins from propositions accepted as divinely disclosed through prophets, scripture or authoritative tradition. It systematises and interprets truths that reason could not discover, or could not know securely and universally, by itself. In Aquinas, doctrines such as Trinity and Incarnation are mysteries: they exceed reason without contradicting it. Reason remains active within revealed theology by clarifying terms, drawing implications, resolving apparent inconsistencies and defending credibility.

The propositional model therefore presents a structured sequence:

1. God communicates truth-content.
2. Prophetic or scriptural testimony mediates it.
3. Faith assents to it as divine testimony.
4. Theology organises the propositions into doctrine.

This model differs from Hick's non-propositional account, where revelation is primarily divine action or self-presence and propositions are human interpretations of encounter. The comparison shows that natural/revealed theology is not identical with reason/irrationality: both are intellectual enterprises, but they begin from different epistemic sources.

The contrast may therefore be summarised along four axes: natural theology begins from common experience, uses inference, seeks publicly discussable conclusions and normally reaches limited truths; revealed theology begins from accepted disclosure, uses faith-informed interpretation, addresses a believing community and includes mysteries unavailable to unaided inquiry.

Two problems arise. First, a propositional revelation may be authenticated circularly: scripture validates the community and the community validates scripture. Second, rival scriptures advance incompatible propositions. Defenders therefore appeal cumulatively to coherence, testimony, historical context, moral fruits and experience rather than to bare self-certification.

Indian comparison requires care. Mīmāṃsā accepts the *apauruṣeya* Veda as an independent *śabda-pramāṇa*, but not as propositions spoken by a creator God. It resembles revealed theology in disclosing supersensible dharma, yet differs from creator-centred divine communication. Advaita further joins *śruti* with *manana* and *nididhyāsana*.

Hence natural theology reasons toward truths available without special disclosure; revealed theology reasons from divinely disclosed propositions. Their distinction concerns epistemic starting point, not the presence versus absence of reason. A defensible propositional model makes revelation supra-rational and reason-governed, never anti-rational.

Why this earns marks:

- Treats the propositional context as central, not decorative.
- Distinguishes source, method, content and accessibility.
- Adds Hick as the precise rival model.
- Uses Indian parity without misclassifying *apauruṣeya* Veda as creator-speech.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE - 6 MODELS

ORIGINAL 1 - 10 marks

Question: "Supra-rational faith need not be irrational." Explain, and state the conditions under which this defence succeeds.

Demand decoding: Define all three categories, defend supra-rationality, and specify safeguards that prevent it from becoming disguised fideism.

Model solution: The supra-rational is what exceeds demonstrative proof; the irrational is what contradicts reason, decisive evidence or moral criticism. **Faith may be supra-rational without being irrational when commitment outruns coercive evidence but remains grounded, coherent and defeasible.**

Aquinas supplies the basic model. Reason can establish preambles and motives of credibility, while revealed mysteries are not demonstrable. Faith is firm intellectual assent under the command of will: it goes beyond proof, yet cannot contradict truth reached by reason. William James provides a secular epistemic limit. Passional commitment is legitimate only when an option is living, forced and momentous and evidence is genuinely inconclusive; his argument does not authorise belief against evidence.

Kierkegaard's objective uncertainty shows why existential relation cannot be replaced by detached proof. Yet his Abrahamic case exposes the danger: if "paradox" suspends every ethical check, supra-rationality becomes irrational immunity. Indian *śraddhā* offers a corrective. In Advaita, trust enables *śravaṇa*, but *manana* removes doubt and *nididhyāsana* directs understanding toward assimilation. Buddhist *saddhā* is similarly verification-directed.

The defence therefore succeeds under four conditions: the faith-claim is internally coherent; it does not contradict secure evidence; it remains answerable to moral fruits; and it admits possible defeaters. Competing revelations must also be compared rather than insulated.

The objection that any non-evidential commitment is arbitrary confuses absence of demonstration with absence of grounds. Testimony, experience and cumulative coherence may rationally support a commitment without compelling it.

Thus supra-rational faith is defensible as responsible trust under uncertainty. It becomes irrational when "beyond reason" is used to mean "against reason" or "immune to correction."

Why this earns marks:

- Defines the decisive threefold distinction.
- Uses Aquinas, James, Kierkegaard and *śraddhā* to build one argument.
- States clear success-conditions and a direct verdict.

ORIGINAL 2 - 10 marks

Question: Is scriptural testimony necessarily a form of revelation by a personal God? Discuss with reference to Mīmāṃsā and theistic models.

Demand decoding: Separate testimonial authority from personal divine speech. Compare rather than assimilate Mīmāṃsā and Abrahamic/theistic propositional revelation.

Model solution: Scriptural testimony need not be conceived as revelation spoken by a personal God. **Theistic propositional models and Mīmāṃsā both grant scripture supersensible authority, but they ground that authority in fundamentally different ways.**

In a creator-centred propositional model, God communicates truth-content through prophets or scripture. The proposition is accepted because divine knowledge and veracity underwrite it; faith receives the testimony, while reason examines coherence and credibility. Aquinas distinguishes truths accessible to natural reason from mysteries known through such revelation.

Mīmāṃsā rejects this author-centred structure. The Veda is *apauruṣeya* - authorless, neither human nor divine composition. Its authority does not depend on proving an omniscient speaker. Vedic *śabda* independently discloses dharma, a supersensible domain unavailable to perception. The absence of an author also removes ordinary defects such as ignorance or deceit.

The similarity is epistemic: both accounts hold that testimony may disclose what perception and inference cannot independently establish. The difference is theological: one relies on a trustworthy personal revealer; the other treats an eternal linguistic tradition as intrinsically authoritative. Therefore calling the Veda "God's revelation" misrepresents Mīmāṃsā.

An objection is that authorless sentences cannot intend or communicate anything. Mīmāṃsā replies by grounding meaning in stable word-meaning relations and an eternal textual tradition, not in a first speaker's intention. Critics may

still question how intrinsic authority handles conflicting texts.

Thus scriptural authority and personal revelation overlap but are not identical. Mīmāṃsā proves that a tradition can defend supersensible testimony without positing a divine speaker, though it must meet its own problems of meaning and cross-tradition warrant.

Why this earns marks:

- Preserves the exact *apauruṣeya* distinction.
- Compares source, warrant and content rather than merely listing schools.
- Includes a philosophical objection and a qualified conclusion.

ORIGINAL 3 - 15 marks

Question: Does Hick's non-propositional account make revelation more intelligible at the cost of making it subjective? Critically examine.

Demand decoding: Reconstruct Hick's event/encounter model, explain its advantage over dictated propositions, present the projection and diversity objections, and assess whether his safeguards are adequate.

Model solution: Hick makes revelation more intelligible by treating it as divine self-disclosure in history and experience rather than as a deposit of dictated propositions. **The cost is not outright subjectivism, but a serious dependence on interpretive faith that makes public adjudication difficult.**

The model proceeds in four stages. First, God acts or becomes present in events and encounter. Second, historical events are religiously ambiguous: they can receive both secular and providential descriptions. Third, faith apprehends the event through "experiencing-as." Fourth, communities formulate propositions and doctrines as concept-laden interpretations of the encounter. Revelation is therefore primarily personal and historical; doctrine is secondary articulation.

This account has major strengths. It acknowledges that scripture is mediated through language, culture and community rather than mechanically dictated. It explains doctrinal diversity without necessarily denying an objective divine initiative. It also clarifies why faith is indispensable to reception: an occurrence becomes revelation *for* someone only when recognised and appropriated. The model resembles the difference between encountering a person and listing propositions about that person.

However, the projection objection is powerful. If interpretation constitutes revelatory meaning, how can one distinguish divine disclosure from expectation, political interest or psychological need? Competing religions experience incompatible events as revelatory. Moral transformation is not decisive, because false beliefs may also produce courage or solidarity. Internal coherence is insufficient, because several incompatible systems may each cohere.

Hick can reply that interpretation does not create reality. Experience is concept-laden in ordinary perception as well; this does not make the external world subjective. Revelatory interpretations face the resistance of events, communal memory, rational criticism and moral-spiritual fruits. A cumulative test - coherence, testimony, transformation and comparative explanatory power - can exclude arbitrary projections.

Yet the propositional realist presses a further objection: unless some divine truth-content controls interpretation, the model cannot say what God has actually disclosed. Hick's view may answer that propositions remain indispensable, but as fallible interpretations rather than revelation's primary form. This protects humility while weakening claims to doctrinal infallibility.

Indian comparison supports a mediated account without collapsing into pure subjectivity. Advaita begins with *śruti*, then subjects understanding to *manana* and culminates in assimilative insight through *nididhyāsana*. Trust, conceptual interpretation and transformation interact. Mīmāṃsā, by contrast, gives linguistic testimony a more objective authority and therefore resembles the propositional pole, though without a creator-speaker.

The verdict is graded. Hick successfully explains revelation as encounter, the need for faith and the historical plurality of doctrines. He does not make revelation merely subjective, because he retains an objective divine pole. Nevertheless, his criteria yield defeasible community-relative warrant rather than universal proof. The model is strongest as an account of how revelation is received, weaker as a test of which alleged revelation is true.

Why this earns marks:

- Reconstructs the model before criticising it.

- Separates interpretive mediation from reality-creation.
- Uses projection, diversity and propositional-realist objections with replies.
- Adds an analytically relevant Indian comparison and graded verdict.

ORIGINAL 4 - 15 marks

Question: Does the doctrine of proper basicity solve the problem of religious justification, or merely relocate it? Examine with an Indian epistemological comparison.

Demand decoding: Explain Plantinga's critique of evidentialism and theory of warrant, assess the Great Pumpkin and diversity objections, and use the exact *svataḥ/parataḥ-prāmāṇya* comparison.

Model solution: Proper basicity solves one problem - the claim that religious belief is irrational unless inferred from evidence - but relocates the deeper problem to **grounding, defeaters and religious diversity**.

Classical evidentialism holds that rational beliefs must be self-evident, incorrigible, evident to the senses, or inferred from such foundations. Plantinga argues that this criterion is self-referentially incoherent because it satisfies none of its own conditions. It is also too narrow: beliefs about memory, other minds and the past are ordinarily rational without being inferred from a classical base.

Theistic belief may therefore be **properly basic**. Experiences of guilt, gratitude, wonder or scriptural encounter can ground belief directly rather than function as premises in an argument. In *Warranted Christian Belief*, Plantinga adds that a true belief has warrant when produced by cognitive faculties functioning properly in an appropriate environment according to a truth-aimed design plan. If a *sensus divinitatis* exists and functions properly, belief in God may be warranted.

This answers the *de jure* objection that theistic belief is inherently irrational. It also restores parity with ordinary non-inferential beliefs. Yet the Great Pumpkin objection asks why arbitrary fantasies cannot claim the same status. Plantinga replies that basicity requires appropriate circumstances, grounding and proper function, and remains defeasible. The reply excludes whim but invites a further difficulty: rival religious communities also possess mature practices, experiences and internal criteria.

Religious diversity thus relocates the issue. If incompatible beliefs are basic within different traditions, justification may become community-relative. Evil, projection and cognitive-science explanations can also serve as defeaters. Plantinga does not make belief immune; a believer must answer these challenges. William Alston's doxastic-practice approach similarly secures practical rationality without supplying a neutral proof of reliability.

Indian epistemology makes the structure clearer. Mīmāṃsā's *svataḥ-prāmāṇya* holds that cognition presents itself as valid until defeated; this is the closest analogue of proper basicity. Nyāya's *parataḥ-prāmāṇya* requires validity to be certified by further cognition and resembles evidentialism. Cārvāka provides the strict limit by refusing supersensible sources. The comparison shows that the dispute is not uniquely Christian; it concerns whether validity is default or earned.

The strongest evidentialist objection is that public accountability is lost. The proper-basicity reply is that accountability shifts from inferential origin to grounding, proper function and response to defeaters. That shift is legitimate but incomplete because no neutral rule decides between mature rival practices.

Therefore proper basicity genuinely defeats the claim that only inferred religious belief can be rational. It does not settle truth or inter-religious conflict. It relocates justification from "Where is the proof?" to "Is the belief properly grounded, undefeated and comparatively responsible?"

Why this earns marks:

- Distinguishes rationality, warrant and truth.
- Reconstructs Plantinga before applying the objections.
- Uses the exact Mīmāṃsā-Nyāya parity.
- Gives a discriminating "solves and relocates" verdict.

ORIGINAL 5 - 20 marks

Question: Can testimony to miracles authenticate a claim to revelation? Evaluate Hume's challenge and its major replies, with an Indian comparison.

Demand decoding: Explain what miracle testimony is supposed to prove, reconstruct both parts of Hume's argument, assess definitional, testimonial and Bayesian replies, and compare the Indian reluctance to use marvels as authentication.

Model solution: Miracles are often offered as public signs that authenticate a prophet, scripture or divine intervention. Yet a miracle report can support revelation only if the event is credible, religiously interpretable and sufficiently connected to the alleged disclosure. **Hume shows that miracle testimony bears an exceptionally heavy burden; his critics show that the burden is not in principle impossible to meet. Even successful testimony would underdetermine a complete revelation.**

In Section X of *An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding*, Hume defines a miracle as a violation of the laws of nature. His Part I argument is an evidential balance. A wise person proportions belief to evidence. Laws of nature rest on uniform experience, whereas testimony rests on the less-than-uniform reliability of human witnesses. The report therefore confronts very strong counter-evidence. Hume's maxim is that no testimony establishes a miracle unless its falsehood would be more miraculous than the reported event; even then, one subtracts the lesser improbability from the greater.

Part II adds four empirical cautions. No miracle, Hume claims, has sufficient attestation from witnesses of exceptional competence and integrity with public reputations at risk. Human beings possess a passion for surprise and wonder. Miracle reports flourish in credulous contexts or descend from them. Finally, contrary miracles offered by rival religions undermine one another because they authenticate incompatible systems. These considerations remain a powerful checklist against fraud, exaggeration and sectarian confirmation bias.

Several replies limit Hume's conclusion. First, the **definitional reply** argues that if a law means an exceptionless regularity, a genuine exception merely shows that the law was misstated; defining miracle as "violation" prejudges the case. Richard Swinburne therefore describes a miracle as a non-repeatable counter-instance to an otherwise well-confirmed law.

Second, Swinburne's principles of credulity and testimony grant apparent experience and report *prima facie* credibility unless reasons for doubt arise. Hume risks making testimony powerless exactly where it concerns an extraordinary event. Still, extraordinary claims reasonably require stronger controls against dependence, deception and alternative causes.

Third, John Earman's Bayesian criticism distinguishes prior from posterior probability. A very low prior probability can be overcome by multiple sufficiently reliable and independent witnesses. Hume's rhetoric of "uniform experience" does not mathematically prove that no testimonial evidence can cross the threshold. The reply establishes possibility, not that any actual miracle report succeeds.

Fourth, Hume's contrary-miracles argument may overstate cancellation. Rival reports should be assessed individually, and miracles need not support mutually exclusive total systems. Nevertheless, doctrinal underdetermination remains: even if an extraordinary healing occurred, it would not by itself establish which deity acted, why, or whether an entire creed is true.

The circularity objection also matters. To say that experience is uniformly against miracles may presuppose that all miracle reports are false. Hume can answer that "uniform" means the best-established regularity, not a conclusion reached after rejecting every report. His cautious Part II survives more securely than the absolute force often attributed to Part I.

Indian traditions provide a revealing contrast. Patañjali's *Yoga-sūtra* 3.37 treats *siddhis* as obstacles to *samādhi* despite their status as outward accomplishments. In the *Kevaddha Sutta*, the Buddha rejects displays of psychic power as a means of conversion and privileges the transformative "miracle of instruction." Mīmāṃsā grounds Vedic authority in *apauruṣeya* status, not miraculous authentication. These traditions do not uniformly deny extraordinary powers; they question their soteriological and epistemic relevance.

A defender may reply that a miracle's purpose is precisely contextual: an event joined to a morally serious message, prior prediction and durable transformation can form part of a cumulative case. This is stronger than treating marvel alone as proof. Yet the context itself is interpreted through faith, returning the argument to Hick's "experiencing-as" and the problem of competing revelations.

Therefore miracle testimony can at most contribute defeasible evidence to a revelation-claim. Hume rightly imposes rigorous scrutiny but does not establish impossibility. Even when credible testimony makes an extraordinary event

probable, authentication requires further argument connecting the event to divine agency and a specific message. Miracles may reinforce faith within an interpretive framework; they rarely compel assent outside it.

Why this earns marks:

- Reconstructs Hume's Part I and Part II distinctly.
- Evaluates Swinburne, Earman, circularity and contrary-miracle replies.
- Separates occurrence, divine agency and doctrinal authentication.
- Uses Indian material as a genuine contrast and reaches a graded verdict.

ORIGINAL 6 - 20 marks

Question: Does revelation require a divine speaker? Compare creator-centred revelation with Mīmāṃsā, Nyāya and Advaita accounts of *śabda* and spiritual knowledge.

Demand decoding: Analyse the conceptual link between revelation and personal agency. Compare Western propositional and encounter models with distinct Indian positions, avoiding the false claim that all authoritative scripture is God's speech.

Model solution: Revelation is commonly defined as divine self-disclosure, which appears to require a personal revealer. Yet Indian theories of *śabda* show that supersensible disclosure can be defended without a creator-speaker. **A divine speaker is necessary for creator-centred propositional revelation, but not for every philosophically defensible model of scriptural or transformative disclosure.**

In the propositional theistic model, God communicates truth-content through prophets, scripture or authoritative tradition. Divine omniscience and veracity ground the authority of the propositions. Aquinas distinguishes truths accessible to natural reason from mysteries known through revelation. Faith assents to divine testimony, while reason tests credibility, draws implications and rules out contradiction. This model provides a clear intentional source: someone reveals something to someone.

Its strengths are objectivity and doctrinal determinacy. Revelation does not depend entirely on the recipient's construction; propositions specify what is disclosed. Its problems are equally clear. Human mediation creates questions of inspiration and error. Authentication may be circular, and rival scriptures claim incompatible divine origins. A perfect speaker does not guarantee a perfectly transmitted or interpreted message.

Hick loosens the dependence on speech without abandoning divine agency. In the non-propositional model, God reveals the divine self through acts, presence and encounter. Historical events are experienced as revelatory, while doctrinal propositions are human interpretations. A personal revealer remains, but not necessarily a dictated sentence. This model handles historical mediation and plurality better, though it increases the projection problem.

Mīmāṃsā offers the strongest challenge to the divine-speaker requirement. The Veda is *apauruṣeya* - authorless and beginningless, neither human composition nor creator-speech. Its authority concerns dharma, which perception cannot disclose. Because there is no author, ordinary defects such as ignorance and deceit do not arise.

Word-meaning relations and the textual tradition carry meaning without dependence on a first speaker's intention. Thus authoritative supersensible testimony is possible without revelation by a person.

The Mīmāṃsā view faces objections. Meaning seems connected to communicative intention; conflicting texts challenge intrinsic authority; and a tradition cannot validate itself merely by declaring authorlessness. Mīmāṃsā responds through linguistic eternality, hermeneutical rules and *svataḥ-prāmāṇya*, according to which cognition is valid until defeated. This secures default authority, though not neutral acceptance across traditions.

Nyāya supplies a contrasting testimonial model. *Śabda* is an independent *pramāṇa* when it is the statement of a reliable speaker, an *āpta*. Here personal competence and sincerity matter. Later Nyāya can connect Vedic authority with Īśvara, but the general epistemology of testimony does not reduce every warranted utterance to revelation. Its *parataḥ-prāmāṇya* demands extrinsic certification, providing stronger public checks than Mīmāṃsā at the cost of regress or dependence on further evidence.

Advaita combines scriptural disclosure, reason and realisation. *Śruti* is indispensable for Brahman, which cannot be objectified through perception or ordinary inference. Yet reception proceeds through *śravaṇa*, *manana* and *nididhyāsana*: hearing the teaching, removing doubt through reasoning, and assimilating insight. *Śraddhā* is disciplined trust that enables inquiry. The authority of *śruti* is not best described as a creator God's verbal intervention;

it is a unique means of knowledge whose teaching culminates in direct recognition rather than permanent dependence on propositions.

These positions reveal at least three meanings of "revelation": **personal propositional communication**, **personal self-disclosure in encounter**, and **non-personal scriptural disclosure of a supersensible domain**. If the term is defined strictly as an intentional act of God, Mīmāṃsā cannot count as revelation. If it is used more broadly for authoritative disclosure unavailable to ordinary perception and inference, Mīmāṃsā and Advaita become genuine comparators. Conceptual clarity requires stating which sense is intended.

The theistic objection is that authorless or impersonal disclosure cannot select, intend or guarantee a message. The Indian reply is that epistemic authority need not always derive from a speaker: perception too informs without an intending author, and Mīmāṃsā treats linguistic cognition as independently valid. However, unlike perception, scripture is linguistically and historically transmitted, so hermeneutic and cross-tradition defeaters remain.

Accordingly, revelation does not universally require a divine speaker. It requires one only within a creator-centred intentional definition. A wider epistemology of disclosure can ground authority in authorless *śabda*, reliable testimony or transformative realisation. The cost of widening the term is reduced theological specificity; the gain is a genuinely comparative philosophy of religion that distinguishes disclosure from divine dictation.

Why this earns marks:

- Builds a three-model conceptual map rather than forcing false equivalence.
- Treats Mīmāṃsā, Nyāya and Advaita separately and accurately.
- Includes source, warrant, mediation and defeater analysis.
- Gives a conditional verdict tied to the definition of revelation.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Advanced-dossier reconciliation - [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

The dossier confirms that Reformed epistemology versus evidentialism is now core, while full proper-function machinery remains optional. Public testimony and private disclosure should be treated as defeasible and cumulative; doxastic voluntarism concerns indirect control through attention and practice rather than instant choice; and Mīmāṃsā/Advaita *śabda* must not be redescribed as creator-dictated scripture.

9. ADVANCED DOCTRINE DOSSIERS

9.1 Natural reason and natural theology

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: Reason can infer and test some religious claims without relying on a special historical disclosure.
- **Argument.** FACT: It identifies publicly accessible premises, derives implications, tests coherence, and distinguishes demonstration, probability and practical postulation.
- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: Reality is intelligible and reason is not wholly corrupted or confined to empirical objects.
- **Distinction.** FACT: Natural theology differs from philosophy of religion: the former argues toward theological conclusions; the latter also analyses language, experience and warrant.
- **Canonical examples.** FACT: Aquinas' preambles of faith; Nyāya inference to Īśvara.
- **Objection -> reply.** ANALYSIS: Kant restricts speculative reason beyond possible experience. Natural theologians reply that metaphysical inference concerns conditions of experience, not another observed object.

9.2 Propositional revelation

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: Revelation communicates divinely authorised truths that unaided reason could not discover or securely know.
- **Argument.** FACT: (1) God can disclose; (2) prophets/scripture mediate disclosure; (3) signs, testimony and coherence warrant reception; (4) doctrine articulates revealed content.
- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: A personal God acts in history and reliable transmission is possible.

- **Distinction.** FACT: Inspiration concerns divine-human authorship; revelation concerns disclosure; infallibility concerns freedom from error. They are not interchangeable.
- **Canonical examples.** FACT: Aquinas distinguishes truths accessible to reason from mysteries known through revelation; Mīmāṃsā's *apauruṣeya* Veda is authoritative but not a creator God's speech.
- **Objection -> reply.** ANALYSIS: Rival revelations and circular authentication weaken certainty. Replies appeal to cumulative criteria-coherence, moral fruit, testimony and transformative power-without pretending neutrality.

9.3 Non-propositional revelation and Hick

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: Revelation is primarily divine self-disclosure in events and encounter; propositions are human interpretations of that disclosure.
- **Argument.** FACT: (1) Events are religiously ambiguous; (2) faith perceives them as divine action; (3) communities conceptualise that encounter; (4) doctrinal diversity reflects interpretive schemes.
- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: Experience is always concept-laden and divine freedom is not exhausted by statements.
- **Distinction.** FACT: An event is not automatically revelation for every observer; "revelatory event" names an experienced-as structure.
- **Canonical example.** FACT: The same historical event can be described in secular causal terms or received as providential.
- **Objection -> reply.** ANALYSIS: If interpretation constitutes revelation, projection threatens. Hick replies through moral-spiritual transformation and the resistance of reality to arbitrary interpretation.

9.4 Aquinas on faith as intellectual assent

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: Faith is an act of intellect assenting to divine truth under the command of will moved by grace.
- **Argument.** FACT: (1) Revealed truth exceeds demonstrative sight; (2) testimony supplies the object; (3) will commits intellect where evidence is non-coercive; (4) grace orients the person toward divine truth.
- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: Will can responsibly govern assent without making truth arbitrary, and divine testimony is trustworthy.
- **Distinction.** FACT: Faith is not opinion: it has firm assent; it is not knowledge in the strict demonstrative/vision sense: its object is unseen.
- **Canonical example.** FACT: Reason may establish that God exists, while Trinity remains a mystery accepted on revelation.
- **Objection -> reply.** ANALYSIS: Will-governed belief risks voluntarism. Aquinas replies that motives of credibility and rational preambles make assent reasonable though not demonstrative.

9.5 Kierkegaardian faith and Indian śraddhā

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: Kierkegaardian faith is passionate commitment amid objective uncertainty; Indian *śraddhā* is disciplined trust that enables inquiry and practice rather than blind credulity.
- **Argument.** FACT: Existential relation cannot be replaced by detached proof; commitment shapes the knower. In the *Gītā* and Vedāntic pedagogy, trust in teacher/scripture initiates verification through practice and insight.
- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: Transformative truths require participation, not observation alone.
- **Distinction.** FACT: Supra-rational is not irrational: exceeding proof differs from contradicting reason.
- **Canonical examples.** FACT: Abraham dramatises Kierkegaard's paradox; *śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana* moves from hearing through reasoning to assimilation.
- **Objection -> reply.** ANALYSIS: Unchecked commitment can sanctify fanaticism. Reply: authentic faith remains answerable to coherence, ethical fruit and self-critical interpretation.

9.6 Science and religion: the four models (2020 Q5(a) owner-module)

[!IMPORTANT] **ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Recommended opening**

definition: Science explains empirically testable processes, while religion addresses ultimate meaning, value and, at times, claims that intersect with evidence. **Core argument/criticism:** Conflict and complete independence are too crude; dialogue and qualified integration are stronger where boundary questions arise, but empirical claims remain answerable to evidence. **Final verdict:** The defensible relation is critical dialogue with local conflict, not permanent warfare or effortless harmony.

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: The standard philosophical map of the science-religion relation is **Ian Barbour's fourfold typology** (*Religion and Science: Historical and Contemporary Issues*, 1997; *When Science Meets Religion*, 2000): **Conflict, Independence, Dialogue, Integration**.
- **The four models, with their arguments and costs.**
 1. **Conflict.** FACT: Science and religion make competing claims about the same world, so one must yield. Two mirror-image versions: scientific materialism (only what science certifies is real) and biblical/scriptural literalism. The historiographical support is the "**warfare thesis**" of **John William Draper** (*History of the Conflict between Religion and Science*, 1874) and **Andrew Dickson White** (*A History of the Warfare of Science with Theology in Christendom*, 1896). ANALYSIS: **Important discipline:** the warfare thesis is now rejected by most historians of science as a polemical nineteenth-century construction; saying so is a mark-earning qualification, not a digression.
 2. **Independence.** FACT: The two occupy separate domains, ask different questions and use different languages, so they cannot conflict. **Stephen Jay Gould's NOMA - Non-Overlapping Magisteria** (*Rocks of Ages*, 1999): science covers the empirical realm of fact and theory, religion the realm of ultimate meaning and moral value. Neo-orthodox theology and Wittgensteinian language-game readings give the same result from different premises. Cost: it purchases peace by forbidding either side to say anything the other could contest, which few believers or scientists accept.
 3. **Dialogue.** FACT: The domains are distinct but touch at **boundary questions** - why there is a universe at all, why it is intelligible, why the constants permit life - and at **methodological parallels** (models, metaphors, paradigms, the theory-ladenness of data in both). Cost: fruitful but non-committal; it establishes conversation, not conclusions.
 4. **Integration.** FACT: Substantive contact: natural theology (fine-tuning arguments), theology of nature (revising doctrine in the light of evolution and cosmology), and systematic syntheses such as **process thought**. Cost: hostage to the science of the day; yesterday's integration becomes tomorrow's embarrassment.
- ANALYSIS: **John Haught's parallel typology** - *Conflict, Contrast, Contact, Confirmation* - is a legitimate alternative to cite, with "Confirmation" adding the claim that religion positively supports the scientific enterprise by underwriting the world's intelligibility.
- **Indian parity (mandatory for this file).** FACT: The Indian tradition supplies distinctive material rather than a mere echo. **Vivekananda** presented Vedānta as the tradition most able to accept scientific findings because it grounds religion in verifiable experience rather than dogma, and described the disciplines of realisation as a "**science of the soul**" - a strong claim that must be reported as a claim, not endorsed. **Radhakrishnan** treats scientific and religious knowing as different levels of one integral experience. **Aurobindo's** evolutionary metaphysics is an explicit integration model. ANALYSIS: The classical *pramāṇa* framework already contains the epistemological core of the debate: whether *śabda* (testimony) is an independent source of knowledge alongside *pratyakṣa* and *anumāna* is exactly the "can revelation add anything?" question in Indian dress - Cārvāka says no, Nyāya and Mīmāṃsā say yes.
- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: That "science" and "religion" name two stable, comparable things - a presupposition that the historicist critique denies, since both categories are modern and internally plural.
- **Objection -> reply.** ANALYSIS: **Objection:** the typology is descriptively neat but normatively empty - it does not tell you which model is *correct*. **Reply:** it is a classification of positions, and the argument must be made model by model; the defensible position is usually a **domain-sensitive mixture** - independence about method, dialogue about boundary questions, conflict only where a religious claim is genuinely empirical.
- **Verdict formula.** ANALYSIS: "Neither wholesale conflict nor wholesale independence survives scrutiny. Conflict overgeneralises from a few historically distorted episodes; independence saves the peace by silencing both parties. The defensible position is **dialogue at the boundary questions with local conflict where an empirical claim is actually made** - and that verdict, not a narrative of Galileo, is what the question wants."

9.7 Faith and belief - the distinction, and the tenets of faith (2020 Q7(c) owner-module)

[!IMPORTANT] **ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Recommended opening**

definition: Belief ordinarily assents to a proposition, whereas faith entrusts the person to an ultimate object and reshapes conduct. **Core argument/criticism:** The reduction of faith to weak belief misses its volitional, relational and performative dimensions, though faith still includes beliefs that remain open to criticism. **Final verdict:** Faith and belief overlap, but faith is not merely a lower degree of evidential certainty.

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: **Belief** is propositional assent - *believing that* p. **Faith** is a fiducial and volitional relation - *believing in*, trusting, entrusting oneself to. Every faith involves beliefs; not every belief involves faith.
- **The distinction, in five axes.** ANALYSIS:

Axis	Belief	Faith
Object	A proposition	A person, reality or ultimate
Grammar	<i>Believe that</i>	<i>Believe in / trust</i>
Mode	Cognitive assent	Assent plus trust, commitment, risk
Voluntariness	Largely involuntary (one cannot decide to believe it is raining)	Involves the will; faith can be <i>given</i>
Failure-mode	Falsehood	Betrayal, infidelity, apostasy
Degrees	Degrees of confidence	Degrees of fidelity and depth

- **The canonical supports.** FACT: **Aquinas'** scholastic pair: *fides quae creditur* (the faith **which** is believed - the content, the creed) and *fides qua creditur* (the faith **by which** one believes - the act and disposition). FACT: **Wilfred Cantwell Smith**, *Faith and Belief* (1979): "faith" names a universal, cross-cultural human orientation to transcendence, whereas "belief" in its modern propositional sense is a historically recent narrowing - the word once meant something closer to "hold dear" (*by-lieve*, cognate with *lieve*). FACT: **Tillich**: faith is the state of being grasped by an **ultimate concern**, which is why idolatry (an ultimate concern in something non-ultimate) is faith's characteristic failure, not unbelief. FACT: **Buber**: the *I-Thou* relation cannot be reduced to *I-It* propositions.
- **The "basic tenets of faith" (the printed stem asks for these - enumerate them).** ANALYSIS: (1) an **object** held to be ultimate; (2) **assent** to some content about it; (3) **trust** exceeding the available evidence; (4) **commitment** of the will, with consequent risk; (5) **hope** oriented to a future not yet secured; (6) a **community** and tradition that transmits and disciplines it; (7) **fruits** - a transformed pattern of life by which it is tested.
- **Indian parity.** FACT: **Śraddhā** is precisely the faith-side rather than the belief-side: the Gītā 17.2-3 grades śraddhā as sāttvika, rājasa or tāmasa and states that a person is constituted by their śraddhā - "as is one's śraddhā, so is one". FACT: In Advaita pedagogy śraddhā is one of the six inner accomplishments and functions as **the trust that makes inquiry possible**, to be replaced by realisation, not preserved as belief. FACT: Buddhism's saddhā is explicitly provisional and verification-directed - the Kālāma Sutta (AN 3.65) counsels not to accept a teaching merely on report, lineage, scripture, logic or the teacher's authority, but to test it in experience. ANALYSIS: This gives Indian material a genuine advantage on this question: śraddhā/saddhā is trust that **initiates verification**, whereas Western "faith" often has to defend itself as trust that replaces* verification.
- **Objection -> reply.** ANALYSIS: **Objection:** the distinction is verbal; "believing in" reduces to "believing that a certain being exists and is trustworthy". **Reply:** the reduction loses the performative and relational element - one can believe *that* a person is reliable while refusing to entrust anything to them; faith is constituted by the entrusting. ANALYSIS: **Second objection:** if faith is volitional it is doxastically irresponsible. **Reply:** the will operates where evidence is genuinely non-coercive, which is the only case in dispute (Aquinas; James's "genuine option" in *The Will to Believe*).
- **Verdict formula.** ANALYSIS: "Faith is not a weaker belief; it is a different act. Belief is the cognitive component *within* faith, and the two can come apart in both directions - orthodox belief without trust, and trust that outruns any belief its holder can articulate."

9.8 Miracles: Hume's argument and its critics

[!IMPORTANT] **ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Recommended opening**

definition: A miracle is an event interpreted as an extraordinary act of divine agency that exceeds the normal course of nature. **Core argument/criticism:** Hume rightly raises the evidential burden on testimony, but his argument becomes circular if 'miracle' is defined as maximally improbable before the evidence is assessed. **Final verdict:** Miracle testimony can be rationally considered, but only under unusually strict tests of independence, credibility and alternative explanation.

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: Hume, *An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding*, Section X, "Of Miracles" (1748), defines a miracle as "*a violation of the laws of nature*" brought about by a particular volition of the Deity, and argues that testimony can never establish one.
- **Argument (Part I - the a priori balance).** FACT: (1) A wise man proportions his belief to the evidence. (2) The laws of nature are supported by uniform, exceptionless experience - the strongest empirical evidence there is. (3) Testimony is supported by experience of human reliability, which is strong but not uniform. (4) A miracle report therefore sets uniform experience against non-uniform experience, and the weaker must yield. (5) **Hume's maxim:** no testimony suffices to establish a miracle unless its falsehood would be *more miraculous* than the fact it endeavours to establish - and even then one subtracts the lesser marvel from the greater.
- **Argument (Part II - the four a posteriori considerations).** FACT: (a) No miracle is attested by a sufficient number of witnesses of unquestioned good sense, education, integrity and public reputation with much to lose. (b) Human nature has a standing **passion for surprise and wonder**, which multiplies marvellous reports. (c) Miracle reports flourish chiefly among **ignorant and barbarous nations**, or descend from such origins. (d) **Contrary miracles cancel:** since the miracles of rival religions support incompatible systems, each set of testimonies destroys the credit of the others.
- **Replies, with their force.** ANALYSIS:
- **The definitional reply:** if "law of nature" means an exceptionless regularity, a genuine exception simply shows the supposed law was mis-stated - so miracles are defined out of existence rather than disproved. **Richard Swinburne** therefore recasts a miracle as a **non-repeatable counter-instance** to a law that remains otherwise well-confirmed.
- **The evidential reply (Swinburne):** the principles of **credulity** and **testimony** give apparent memory, perception and report a *prima facie* right to be believed; Hume's rule effectively makes them powerless in exactly the case where they might matter, which is question-begging.
- **The Bayesian reply (John Earman, Hume's Abject Failure, 2000):** Hume's argument confuses the *prior* improbability of an event with the *posterior* probability given testimony; multiple independent witnesses of moderate reliability can raise the posterior probability of a very improbable event arbitrarily high.
- **The circularity charge (C. S. Lewis and others):** to know that uniform experience is against miracles, one must already know that all miracle reports are false - which is the conclusion.
- **The contrary-miracles reply:** the cancellation argument assumes rival traditions' miracles support *mutually exclusive* total systems; if traditions overlap in what their miracles are taken to attest, cancellation is not automatic.
- ANALYSIS: **What survives:** Hume's Part II is a permanently useful checklist of *evidential caution*; his Part I is now widely regarded as too strong, since it would exclude testimony for any sufficiently improbable event, including well-attested scientific anomalies.
- **Indian parity.** FACT: The tradition is markedly **unenthusiastic** about the evidential use of the marvellous. Patañjali's *Yoga-sūtra* Book III catalogues the *siddhis/vibhūtis* in detail and then (3.37) declares them **obstacles to samādhi** though "accomplishments" in the outward-turned state - the powers are real but soteriologically worthless. FACT: Buddhism records *iddhi* while the *Kevaddha Sutta* (DN 11) has the Buddha reject the display of psychic powers as a means of gaining converts, preferring the "miracle of instruction". FACT: Mīmāṃsā grounds Vedic authority in *apauruṣeya* eternality precisely so that it needs **no** miraculous authentication. ANALYSIS: Hence, where Western apologetics uses miracles to *authenticate* revelation, Indian systems mostly *decline* the strategy - a genuine comparative point rather than a parallel.
- **Verdict formula.** ANALYSIS: "Hume shows that miracle-testimony faces an unusually heavy evidential burden; he does not show that the burden is in principle unmeetable. The stronger conclusion is that a miracle can at best be evidence **for those already inside** an interpretive framework that identifies which events would count as divine

action - which returns the question to revelation and faith."

9.9 Evidentialism and Reformed epistemology (2023 Q5(b) owner-module)

[!IMPORTANT] **ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Recommended opening**

definition: The justification debate asks whether religious belief requires inferential evidence or may be properly basic yet defeasible. **Core argument/criticism:** Evidentialism protects responsibility but can impose an unduly narrow foundation; Reformed epistemology widens rational basicity but must answer arbitrariness and religious diversity. **Final verdict:** Religious belief may be non-inferentially justified, but it remains vulnerable to defeaters and comparative criticism.

- **The question.** FACT: "Can religious beliefs be justified?" is not the question whether God exists; it is the question of **what standard** a religious belief must meet to be rationally held.
- **Evidentialism.** FACT: **Thesis:** a belief is rational only if it is proportioned to the evidence, and religious belief must meet the same standard as any other. **John Locke** ties assent to the probability of the evidence; **W. K. Clifford** ("The Ethics of Belief", 1877) makes it a *moral* matter - "it is wrong always, everywhere, and for anyone, to believe anything upon insufficient evidence", illustrated by the shipowner who sends an unseaworthy ship to sea on unexamined hope. FACT: **Antony Flew's presumption of atheism:** the burden of proof lies on the affirmative claim, and in the absence of sufficient evidence the rational default is not agnosticism but *not-believing*.
- **Reply (William James, The Will to Believe, 1896):** where an option is **living, forced and momentous**, and the evidence is genuinely inconclusive, our "passional nature" may lawfully decide; Clifford's rule is itself a passional preference for avoiding error over gaining truth. ANALYSIS: James's argument is limited to genuinely undecidable options and does not license belief against evidence.
- **Reformed epistemology.** FACT: **Thesis (Alvin Plantinga, "Reason and Belief in God", 1983; Warranted Christian Belief, 2000):** belief in God can be **properly basic** - rationally held without being inferred from other beliefs.
- **Argument:** (1) The evidentialist objection presupposes **classical foundationalism:** a belief is rational only if self-evident, incorrigible, evident to the senses, or inferred from such. (2) That criterion is **self-referentially incoherent** - it is itself none of those things and is not derivable from them. (3) It is also too narrow: memory beliefs, beliefs in other minds and beliefs about the past are not derived from that base but are plainly rational. (4) So basicity is not confined to the classical foundationalist's list. (5) Belief in God, formed in appropriate circumstances (gratitude, guilt, wonder, reading scripture), is basic in the same way - grounded in experience without being inferred.
- **Warrant and proper function:** for Plantinga, warrant is what turns true belief into knowledge - a belief has warrant when produced by cognitive faculties **functioning properly**, in an appropriate environment, according to a design plan aimed at truth. If Calvin's *sensus divinitatis* exists and works properly, theistic belief has warrant without argument. Note the structure: this shows that **if** theism is true, theistic belief is very likely warranted - so there is no viable *de jure* objection independent of the *de facto* question.
- **The Great Pumpkin objection:** if belief in God can be properly basic, so can belief in anything at all. **Reply:** basicity is not arbitrariness - properly basic beliefs are grounded in circumstances, are defeasible, and belong to a community's disciplined doxastic practice; there is no analogous faculty or ground for the Great Pumpkin. ANALYSIS: Critics respond that this makes the criterion community-relative, which readmits the Son-of-Great-Pumpkin problem for well-established rival traditions.
- FACT: **William Alston's** complementary route (*Perceiving God*, 1991): our engagement in **doxastic practices** - including sense perception - cannot be shown reliable without circularity; since we nonetheless rationally engage in them, socially established religious practice is in the same epistemic boat, and it is practically rational to engage in it absent sufficient reason to think it unreliable. Route to Religious Experience §9.8.
- **Indian parity.** FACT: The whole dispute maps onto the **pramāṇa** debate. Cārvāka is the strict evidentialist - only *pratyakṣa*, so no supersensible belief is justified. Nyāya is the inferentialist - *anumāna* and *āpta-vākya* justify. **Mīmāṃsā's svataḥ-prāmāṇya** (*intrinsic validity: a cognition is valid on its own until defeated*) is the closest classical analogue of Reformed epistemology's proper basicity, and **Nyāya's parataḥ-prāmāṇya** (extrinsic validity: validity must be established by something further) is the closest analogue of evidentialism. ANALYSIS: This mapping is the single most valuable move available in this question, because it converts a Western

epistemology debate into an Indian one without distortion.

- **Objection -> reply.** ANALYSIS: **Objection:** properly basic religious belief is immune to criticism. **Reply:** Plantinga insists it is **defeasible** - the problem of evil, projection theories and cognitive-science explanations are all potential defeaters that must be met. ANALYSIS: **Second objection:** religious diversity means incompatible beliefs are all "properly basic". **Reply:** diversity is a defeater to be answered, not an automatic refutation - but no one holds it is easily answered.
- **Verdict formula.** ANALYSIS: "Religious beliefs can be justified, but not in the way natural theology once hoped. The evidentialist standard, taken strictly, disqualifies far more than religion; the Reformed alternative rescues rationality at the cost of making it internal to a doxastic practice - and then religious diversity, not evidential insufficiency, becomes the real problem."

10. INTER-THINKER / INTER-SCHOOL DEBATES

Position	Reason	Revelation	Faith	Main risk
Rationalism/evidentialism	FACT: Judge of belief	Must be evidenced	Proportioned to evidence	Reduction of commitment
Aquinas	FACT: Preambles and coherence	Mysteries beyond reason	Firm intellectual assent	Two-tier tension
Fideism	ANALYSIS: Limited or irrelevant	Authoritative	Primary leap/trust	Arbitrariness
Hick	FACT: Interprets experience critically	Event/self-disclosure	Experiencing-as	Projection
Mīmāṃsā	FACT: Interprets injunction/testimony	<i>Apauruṣeya</i> Veda, not creator speech	Trust in Vedic authority	Cross-tradition warrant
Advaita	FACT: <i>Manana</i> removes doubt	<i>Śruti</i> discloses Brahman	<i>Śraddhā</i> enables inquiry	Scriptural circularity
Evidentialism (Locke, Clifford, Flew)	FACT: Sole arbiter; proportion assent to evidence	Must be independently evidenced	Rational only if evidenced	Self-application; over-strict criterion
Reformed epistemology (Plantinga)	ANALYSIS: Not the sole arbiter	May be received basically	Properly basic, warranted, defeasible	Religious diversity as a defeater
Alston	FACT: Critical, non-foundationalist	Mediated in practice	Rational participation in a doxastic practice	Circularity shared with sense perception
Barbour's typology	FACT: Model-dependent	Model-dependent	Model-dependent	Descriptive, not normative

11. CRITICISMS AND REPLIES

1. **Evidential challenge.** ANALYSIS: Cliffordian ethics of belief rejects assent without sufficient evidence. **Reply:** testimony, cumulative evidence and practical commitment can be rational without demonstration.
2. **Competing revelation.** ANALYSIS: Rival scriptures cannot all be literally infallible in incompatible claims. **Reply:** distinguish core disclosure from historically conditioned interpretation; critics call this revisionary.
3. **Circularity.** ANALYSIS: Scripture authenticated by the community and community by scripture. **Reply:** many epistemic practices use reciprocal support; the issue is whether the circle is vicious or a coherent web.
4. **Fideist immunity.** ANALYSIS: Faith insulated from criticism licenses fanaticism. **Reply:** faith may transcend proof while remaining constrained by non-contradiction and ethical fruits.

12. COMMON UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not define faith as belief without evidence; distinguish trust, assent and commitment.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not say Aquinas lets faith contradict reason.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not conflate revelation with scripture or inspiration.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not call Mīmāṃsā's Veda revelation from a personal God.

5. ANALYSIS: The common Latin slogan associated with believing "because absurd" should not be quoted as Tertullian's exact wording without qualification.
6. ANALYSIS: In "faith indispensable for revelation," distinguish objective disclosure from subjective reception.
7. ANALYSIS: Do not narrate Galileo and call it the science-religion question. Use **Barbour's four models** (conflict/independence/dialogue/integration) and note that the Draper-White "warfare thesis" is rejected by most historians of science.
8. ANALYSIS: Do not treat NOMA as the obvious solution. Independence buys peace by forbidding both sides to make claims the other could contest - state that cost.
9. ANALYSIS: Do not define faith as "belief without evidence" and then distinguish it from belief. The distinction is **trust/entrusting vs propositional assent**; use *fides qual/fides quae* and Gītā 17.2-3 on *śraddhā*.
10. ANALYSIS: Do not attribute to Hume the claim that miracles are impossible. His claim is about the **evidential force of testimony**; and his definition of a miracle as a violation of natural law is itself contested (Swinburne's non-repeatable counter-instance).
11. ANALYSIS: Do not present Clifford's maxim without James's reply, or James's reply without its restriction to **living, forced and momentous** options where evidence is genuinely inconclusive.
12. ANALYSIS: Do not say Plantinga claims God's existence is self-evident. He claims theistic belief can be **properly basic** - grounded, warranted and **defeasible** - and that classical foundationalism is self-referentially incoherent.
13. ANALYSIS: When comparing, use the exact Indian analogues: Mīmāṃsā's *svataḥ-prāmāṇya* ≈ proper basicity; Nyāya's *parataḥ-prāmāṇya* ≈ evidentialism. Do not assert a looser parallel.

13. KEYWORD & STATEMENT BANK

Keywords: FACT: natural theology · revealed theology · preambles of faith · mystery · propositional/non-propositional revelation · testimony · inspiration · *apauruṣeya* · *śabda* · *pratyakṣa/anumāna* · *svataḥ-prāmāṇya/parataḥ-prāmāṇya* · intellectual assent · *fides qual/fides quae* · will · grace · motives of credibility · evidentialism · ethics of belief · presumption of atheism · living/forced/momentous option · Reformed epistemology · properly basic belief · classical foundationalism · warrant · proper function · *sensus divinitatis* · Great Pumpkin objection · doxastic practice · defeater · fideism · objective uncertainty · experiencing-as · ultimate concern · *śraddhā* · *saddhā* · *śravaṇa* · *manana* · *nididhyāsana* · conflict/independence/dialogue/integration · NOMA · warfare thesis · boundary questions · miracle · violation of a law of nature · non-repeatable counter-instance · principle of credulity · *siddhi/vibhūti*.

Safe formulations: ANALYSIS: "Faith may go beyond coercive proof without going against reason." · "Revelation requires both an alleged disclosure and a warranted mode of reception." · "Faith is not a weaker belief; it is a different act, of which belief is one component." · "Hume raised the evidential bar for miracles; he did not show it unclearable." · "The evidentialist standard, applied strictly, disqualifies far more than religion."

CORPUS-DRIVEN DEPTH DELTA (expanded PYQ audit)

- ANALYSIS: **Priority:** Primary ownership is 11 of 112 parts; 2018 has no owned part, while 2020-2025 broaden the clause beyond a simple reason-versus-faith binary.
- FACT: **Required doctrinal depth:** Required depth includes self-revelation, religion under scientific-technological modernity, faith versus belief, reason as regulative, and the epistemic warrant of revelation.
- WRONG: **Trap / answer consequence:** Do not equate revelation with private feeling or faith with evidence-free belief; separate propositional, personal/event and experiential models.

14. PYQ ROUTING (2018-2025)

ANALYSIS: **Corpus signal:** 11 primary-owned question-parts out of 112. The local Paper II corpus is continuous from 2018 through 2025. Cross-links do not create duplicate ownership.

Year	Question	Marks	Exact demand
2019	Q5(a)	10 marks	What is instrumental to self-revelation: Faith or Reason? Justify your position.
2020	Q5(a)	10 marks	Discuss the significance of 'Religion' vis-à-vis the present scientific and technological development.

Year	Question	Marks	Exact demand
2020	Q7(c)	15 marks	What are the basic tenets of faith? Distinguish between faith and belief.
2021	Q7(a)	20 marks	Discuss the role of reason and faith in religion. Can reason be a regulative force in the formulation of religious beliefs? Explain.
2022	Q5(d)	10 marks	Is the notion of faith indispensable for the idea of revelation? Critically comment.
2023	Q5(b)	10 marks	Can religious beliefs be justified? Discuss.
2023	Q6(c)	15 marks	Explain the rational and irrational aspects of faith in the discourse of religion.
2024	Q5(d)	10 marks	Discuss the role of reason in religion.
2024	Q7(b)	15 marks	What kind of epistemic justifications are possible with regard to claims to revelation? Discuss with your own comments.
2025	Q5(e)	10 marks	How does Aquinas' account of Faith as "an intellectual assent" reconcile the juxtaposition between Reason and Faith? Discuss.
2025	Q6(c)	15 marks	Distinguish between Natural Theology and Revealed Theology in the context of the Propositional view of Revelation.

See the Philosophy of Religion PYQ Bank, 2018-2025.

15. ANSWER ARCHITECTURE (10 / 15 / 20 MARKS)

[!IMPORTANT] **ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM** Recommended opening

definition: A reason-revelation-faith answer should first identify whether the stem concerns source, reception, warrant or commitment. **Core argument/criticism:** Marks rise when one named theory is reconstructed, tested by its strongest objection and compared on one precise Indian-Western axis. **Final verdict:** The best conclusion is graded: faith may exceed coercive proof, but it cannot claim immunity from coherence, evidence and moral criticism.

10 marks

Define reason/revelation/faitb term asked -> doctrine's internal relation -> one distinction -> one objection -> direct verdict.

15 marks

Frame warrant problem -> propositional or encounter model in steps -> criteria of justification -> rival model/Indian comparison -> objection and reply.

20 marks

Map the three concepts -> strongest harmony and conflict models -> presuppositions -> competing-revelation/evidential objections -> Indian-Western comparison -> defended synthesis.

16. DIRECTIVE DECODER

Directive	Examiner is buying	Structural consequence	Live example
What is instrumental to X: A or B? Justify your position	A choice , defended - not "both are important"	Choose, give the strongest case, then concede what the loser explains better	2019 Q5(a) faith or reason for self-revelation
Discuss the significance of X vis-à-vis Y	A relation, modelled	Use a typology (Barbour) rather than a narrative	2020 Q5(a)
What are the basic tenets of X? Distinguish X and Y	Two separate deliverables	Enumerate the tenets; then a differentia table	2020 Q7(c)
Can A be a regulative force in B? Explain	The precise sense of "regulative"	<i>Regulative</i> (constrains, vetoes, disciplines) ≠ <i>constitutive</i> (generates content)	2021 Q7(a)
Critically comment	A short but evaluative verdict (10m)	No survey; one distinction, one objection, one verdict	2022 Q5(d)
Can X be justified? Discuss	The standard of justification, not the truth of X	Name the epistemology first (evidentialist? basic?)	2023 Q5(b)
Explain the rational and irrational aspects of X	Three categories, not two	Rational / supra-rational / irrational - the middle term is the answer	2023 Q6(c)
What kind of epistemic justifications are possible... with your own comments	A typology plus a first-person assessment	List criteria (coherence, testimony, fruits, transformation), then rank them yourself	2024 Q7(b)
How does X reconcile A and B?	The mechanism of reconciliation, stated as a structure	Name the two storeys and the hinge between them	2025 Q5(e) Aquinas
Distinguish A and B in the context of C	A three-term answer; C is not decorative	Natural vs revealed theology as seen from the propositional model	2025 Q6(c)

MEMORY: **Rule:** this clause punishes binaries. Reason/faith, rational/irrational, science/religion and evidence/basicity are all **three-term** distinctions once you add the middle category (supra-rational, dialogue, defeasible basicity).

17. GRADED VERDICT LADDER

Band	What the script contains	Typical fault
Weak (≈40%)	"Reason argues, faith trusts"; Aquinas and Kierkegaard named	No epistemology; faith defined as evidence-free belief
Average (≈50%)	The four stances; propositional/non-propositional revelation	Indian material limited to one sentence on <i>śraddhā</i>
Good (≈60%)	One position reconstructed with premises; one objection answered	Middle category (supra-rational / dialogue / defeasible basicity) missing
Strong (≈65-70%)	Justification standard named; Indian <i>pramāṇa</i> parity used; competing-revelation problem raised	Verdict summarises rather than decides
Top (≈70%+)	All the above + a discriminating distinction (<i>fides qua/ quae</i> ; <i>svataḥ/parataḥ-prāmāṇya</i> ; regulative vs constitutive; violation vs non-repeatable counter-instance) + a statement of the defeater that would change the verdict	-

Graded-verdict templates:

- ANALYSIS: *Reason/faith stem*: "Reason is **regulative** but not **constitutive** of religious belief: it can veto incoherence, discipline interpretation and assess evidence, but it does not generate the content that faith

receives."

- ANALYSIS: *Justification stem*: "Religious beliefs can be justified, but the standard cannot be the strict evidentialist one, which disqualifies memory and other minds as well. Once justification is located inside a doxastic practice, the live objection changes from *insufficient evidence* to *incompatible practices*."
- ANALYSIS: *Revelation stem*: "A revelation-claim is warranted, if at all, by a **convergence** - internal coherence, moral fruits, the recipient's experience, communal transmission and congruence with reason - no one of which is decisive, and none of which is neutral between traditions."

18. FACTUAL AND QUOTATION DISCIPLINE

Item	Status	Safe use
<i>Credo ut intelligam</i>	FACT: Anselmian formula (<i>Proslogion</i> 1, in the "faith seeking understanding" tradition from Augustine)	Attribute to the Augustinian-Anselmian tradition
<i>Credo quia absurdum</i>	CAUTION: Not a verified verbatim Tertullian sentence	Call it "a later slogan for extreme fideism"
Aquinas on faith as a mean between knowledge and opinion	FACT: ST II-II q.1-q.4	Paraphrase; do not fabricate English quotation
Clifford's maxim	FACT: W. K. Clifford , "The Ethics of Belief" (1877)	The shipowner example is his
<i>The Will to Believe</i>	FACT: William James (1896)	The reply is restricted to living, forced, momentous options
"Of Miracles"	FACT: Hume , <i>Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding</i> , Section X	Part I = the maxim; Part II = the four considerations
Non-repeatable counter-instance	FACT: Richard Swinburne 's recasting of "miracle"	Use to show Hume's definition is contestable
<i>Hume's Abject Failure</i>	FACT: John Earman (2000)	The Bayesian critique
Draper-White "warfare thesis"	FACT: Real books (1874, 1896)	ANALYSIS: Now rejected by most historians of science - say so
NOMA	FACT: Stephen Jay Gould , <i>Rocks of Ages</i> (1999)	Independence model
Fourfold typology	FACT: Ian Barbour	Haught's Conflict/Contrast/Contact/Confirmation is the alternative
<i>Faith and Belief</i>	FACT: Wilfred Cantwell Smith (1979)	For the historical narrowing of "belief"
"Reason and Belief in God" / <i>Warranted Christian Belief</i>	FACT: Alvin Plantinga (1983; 2000)	Proper basicity, warrant, proper function, <i>sensus divinitatis</i>
<i>Perceiving God</i>	FACT: William Alston (1991)	Doxastic practices
Gītā 17.2-3 on <i>śraddhā</i>	FACT: Verified chapter/verse	"As is one's <i>śraddhā</i> , so is one" - paraphrase
<i>Kālāma Sutta</i> (AN 3.65), <i>Kevaddha Sutta</i> (DN 11)	FACT: Verified nikāya references	Paraphrase; do not quote a translation as canonical
<i>Yoga-sūtra</i> 3.37 on <i>siddhis</i> as obstacles	FACT: Verified sūtra	The key Indian anti-miracle datum

19. LINK-OUTS

- Proofs for God - what reason can and cannot establish unaided
- Religious Experience - Alston's doxastic practice; experience as a ground of warrant
- Religious Language - verification, falsification and the meaning of religious claims

- Religious Pluralism - competing revelations and the diversity defeater
- Religion without God - Cārvāka's strict evidentialism; Mīmāṃsā's authorless authority
- Paper I: Mīmāṃsā - *apauruṣeya*, *svataḥ-prāmāṇya*
- Paper I: Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika - *śabda* as *pramāṇa*, *parataḥ-prāmāṇya*
- Paper I: Cārvāka - the limit case of evidentialism
- Paper I: Existentialism - Kierkegaard's leap
- Paper I: Kant - the limits of speculative reason
- Philosophy of Religion PYQ Bank, 2018-2025

SOURCES

- Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, II-II qq.1-7 (faith).
- Søren Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript* and *Fear and Trembling*.
- David Hume, *An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding*, Section X; John Earman, *Hume's Abject Failure*.
- W. K. Clifford, "The Ethics of Belief"; William James, *The Will to Believe*.
- Alvin Plantinga, "Reason and Belief in God" and *Warranted Christian Belief*; William Alston, *Perceiving God*.
- Ian Barbour, *Religion and Science*; Stephen Jay Gould, *Rocks of Ages*; John Haught, *Science and Religion*.
- Wilfred Cantwell Smith, *Faith and Belief*; Paul Tillich, *Dynamics of Faith*.
- John Hick, *Philosophy of Religion*.
- Mīmāṃsā, Nyāya and Vedānta discussions in S. C. Chatterjee & D. M. Datta and C. D. Sharma.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

A. Three-term control

- **Reason:** argument, coherence, evidence, interpretation and criticism.
- **Revelation:** alleged divine self-disclosure through proposition, event or encounter.
- **Faith:** assent plus trust, commitment, hope and fidelity.
- Formula: **reason regulates; revelation discloses; faith receives.**

B. Four relation models

Model	Thinker	Core claim	Cost
Rationalism	Locke, Clifford	reason judges every religious claim	can reduce lived commitment
Fideism	Kierkegaard as qualified case	faith transcends proof	arbitrariness if insulated
Faith seeking understanding	Augustine, Anselm	faith initiates rational inquiry	starts within commitment
Two-source harmony	Aquinas	preambles by reason, mysteries by revelation	credibility of revelation remains

C. Revelation distinctions

- Propositional: divinely authorised truths; doctrine articulates content.
- Non-propositional: divine action or presence encountered and interpreted.
- Revelation is not identical with scripture, inspiration or infallibility.
- Objective disclosure and subjective reception must be separated.

D. Aquinas answer spine

1. Faith is an act of intellect.
2. The intellect assents to divine truth.
3. The will commands assent and grace moves the person.
4. Faith is firm like knowledge but lacks demonstrative vision.
5. Reason proves preambles; revelation supplies mysteries.
6. Both derive from God and therefore cannot genuinely contradict.

E. Kierkegaard and supra-rational faith

- Objective uncertainty creates the field for passionate appropriation.
- Leap means existential commitment, not permission to believe contradictions.
- **Supra-rational** exceeds proof; **irrational** violates coherence or evidence.
- Abraham is an existential test, not a general licence for fanaticism.

F. Faith versus belief

Belief	Faith
believes that	believes in / trusts
proposition	person or ultimate
cognitive assent	assent plus entrusting
mainly truth/falsity	fidelity/betrayal
may remain detached	reshapes action and identity

Use *fides quae* for content and *fides qua* for the believing disposition.

G. Science and religion

- Barbour: Conflict, Independence, Dialogue, Integration.
- Warfare thesis: historically overgeneralised.
- NOMA: peace at the cost of mutual silence.
- Best verdict: dialogue at boundary questions, local conflict on empirical claims.
- Technology answers what can be done; ethics and religion contest what ought to be done.

H. Miracles and testimony

- Hume: uniform experience outweighs fallible testimony; rival miracle claims cancel.
- Surviving insight: unusually high evidential burden and witness-quality tests.
- Critiques: contested definition, Bayesian updating, independent testimony, circularity.
- Indian contrast: *siddhis* and displays are often treated as distractions, not authentication.

I. Justification debate

- Evidentialism: proportion belief to evidence; Clifford and Flew.
- James: living, forced, momentous options under genuine evidential indecision.
- Plantinga: properly basic, grounded, warranted and defeasible belief.
- Great Pumpkin: basicity is constrained by grounds, functioning and defeaters.
- Alston: socially established doxastic practices cannot be validated non-circularly.

J. Indian parity

- Mīmāṃsā *svataḥ-prāmāṇya*: cognition valid until defeated.
- Nyāya *parataḥ-prāmāṇya*: validity established through further certification.
- Śabda can be an independent *pramāṇa* without creator-dictation.
- Advaita: *śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana*; reason removes doubt after disclosure.
- Buddhist *saddhā*: provisional trust directed toward verification.

K. Eleven PYQ routes

2019 self-revelation: choose faith for reception, reason for regulation. 2020 science: Barbour, then normative relevance. 2020 faith/belief: seven tenets plus five axes. 2021 regulative reason: regulative is not constitutive. 2022 revelation: objective disclosure versus subjective reception. 2023 justification: evidentialism versus proper basicity. 2023 rational/irrational: add the supra-rational middle. 2024 reason: natural theology, coherence, interpretation and limits. 2024 revelation warrant: convergent, defeasible criteria. 2025 Aquinas: intellect, will, grace, preambles and mysteries. 2025 natural/revealed theology: distinguish them inside the propositional model.

L. Final answer discipline

1. Define the exact disputed term.
2. State whether the question concerns source, reception, warrant or commitment.
3. Reconstruct one named position.
4. Add the strongest objection and reply.
5. Use one precise Indian comparison.
6. End with a graded verdict, not "both are important".

Final judgement: Rational religion is neither proof without trust nor trust without criticism. Faith may go beyond coercive proof, but it forfeits philosophical legitimacy when it claims a right to go against reason.

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

High-yield use: Follow the sessions consecutively as one continuous source-derived teaching and answer-writing route.

Reason, Revelation and Faith – COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

START / CENTRAL QUESTION

Current scholarly anchor – [SUPPORTING]: Inference: The episode gives a contemporary use for the 2020 science-technology PYQ: technical systems can classify and reproduce religious perspectives, but questions of moral authority, fairness and human dignity remain philosophical and normative.

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+-- SESSION 01: CURRENT SCHOLARLY ANCHOR – [SUPPORTING]

| DEFINITION / TERMS : Current scholarly anchor – [SUPPORTING]: Inference: The episode gives a contemporary use for the 2020 science-technology PYQ: technical systems can classify and reproduce religious perspectives, but questions of moral authority, fairness and human dignity remain philosophical and normative.

| MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Inference: The episode gives a contemporary use for the 2020 science-technology PYQ: technical systems can classify and reproduce religious perspectives, but questions of moral authority, fairness and human dignity remain philosophical and normative.

| CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: It does not establish any theological claim.

| TRAP / ANSWER-USE: It does not establish any theological claim.

| EXAM OPENING: Fact: Religion News Service reported on 26 May 2026 that a consortium involving Brigham Young, Baylor, Notre Dame and Yeshiva researchers tested fourteen AI models for multi-faith bias and presented findings at an AI ethics summit in Athens.

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+-- SESSION 02: VISUAL GATEWAY – THE THREE FUNCTIONS

| DEFINITION / TERMS : Visual gateway – the three functions: Final verdict: Reason is best treated as regulative without being assumed to be the sole source of religious truth.

| MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Recommended opening definition: Reason tests coherence and warrant, revelation claims divine self-disclosure, and faith receives that disclosure through trust and commitment.

| CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Core argument/criticism: Propositional models emphasise revealed truths, whereas non-propositional models emphasise divine acts or presence interpreted through human experience.

| TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Master verdict: Reason should be regulative but need not be constitutive.

| EXAM OPENING: Master verdict: Reason should be regulative but need not be constitutive.

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ANSWER-WRITING SPINE

definition -> exact terms -> mechanism/evidence -> consequence/contrast

-> objection/trap -> qualified answer-use